

TEN TOES DOWN PRESENTS / THE COALITION EDITION

The Second Great Butch vs. Stud War

The Panorama of Games for Lillian

VOLUME 2 OF SIX

The Treasury Has Survived the Second Great War

Turn-based strategy, cards and role-playing

Forty real games. One coalition. Aiden has already overspent.

Fictional wars, adult coalition comedy, reclaimed in-group language and innuendo.

New ChatGPT prose under Nolan's creative direction. The 1967 war is invented history.

Coalition Edition 3.0 - 20 September 2026

240 CASES / SIX DEPARTMENTS

ZERO OBLIGATION TO OBEY THE DEPARTMENTS

AIDEN AND TANK / THE COALITION CHORUS

Niggas, games up.

Niggas, pens out.

Niggas, chairs in.

Niggas, snacks here.

Niggas, receipts ready.

Niggas, lights on.

Niggas, mic check.

Niggas, take turns.

Niggas, dance later.

Niggas, read first.

Niggas, pick freely.

Niggas, no rush.

Niggas, sign here.

Niggas, stay petty.

Niggas, we're good.

How to find a game in this book

Each game starts with a short pitch, what you actually do, the controls and pace, the main catch, and a first action to try. These practical sections use plain language. The longer Aiden scene comes after them.

For a fast comparison, read the pitch and main catch on two or three pages. Use the alphabetical index to jump to a title. Choose the full story only when you want the comedy; it is never a prerequisite for understanding the game.

This is an original comic game catalogue inspired by the Aiden ensemble in Ten Toes Down. The source novels remain separate. Game descriptions and catches are research-based editorial notes; the coalition summit and Aiden's rulings are fiction.

The catalogue ranges across possible fits and clearly marked detours. "Waits" describes the usual decision loop, not a certification that every scene is untimed. The labels mean: A place to start = a promising candidate; Read the catch first = a meaningful obstacle needs checking; A more demanding detour = a narrower or harder option. They describe the game, not the reader. Check the exact edition.

Choose any game directly. Skip any game for any reason. The elaborate route is an optional joke; declining never costs a token. No purchase, download, account or medical information is needed to use this book.

Print on Letter paper at actual size, or fit to A4. Page references use volume / page, which remain valid in the omnibus. For larger type, use the reflowable EPUB. Links and a full alphabetical index sit beside the printed case numbers.

The six departments

1. Suspiciously Interesting People - mysteries and adventures
2. Taking One's Turn - strategy and role-playing
3. Looking Around Before Doing Anything - exploration
4. Things That Fit Into Other Things - puzzles and construction
5. People Who Have Something to Tell You - character stories
6. Bringing a Friend - co-op and shared play

AIDEN AND TANK / THE COALITION CHORUS

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Choose a game by its name

This is the quick route. Click any title, or turn to its page. Read the short pitch and main catch first; Aiden's scene follows the practical guide. The case number works across every format.

The long conversation: [Both Sides of the Paper and Who Gets Paid to Hold It](#) - page 27. Money, labor and respectability.

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AIDEN AND TANK / THE COALITION CHORUS

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A route that knows when to shut up

The shortest working procedure

First name up to three real preferences or vetoes: required speed, camera movement, holds, menus, reading, clue tracking or native co-op. Keep them beside you. The route cannot overrule them.

You are in Department 2. Pick one mood row and one emblem column below; neither claims to describe a game feature. That gives a starting case. You can go there now.

For ceremonial excess only, roll four ordinary six-sided dice: 1-2 means minus one; 3-4 means zero; 5-6 means plus one. Add the four results. Add zero, one or two for any already-available wanted drink and wanted snack. Eating is never required.

Begin a browsing session with three imaginary Stamp Tokens. At most once per selection, spend one to add two OR reroll all four dice. You may take an optional funny trait from Book I as your excuse. Never pay a token to refuse a game.

Move that many cases along this department's forty-case shelf, wrapping around at either end. Read the real catch. If you want one appeal, visit the adjacent case or the same local position in another department; then choose freely or stop. No appeal loops.

The printed full rules, worked example and incident desk are in Volume I. The offline index performs the arithmetic and provides conservative evidence filters. The direct alphabetical index near the front always works without dice.

Mood / emblem	1. Envelope	2. Key	3. Plant	4. Map	5. Teacup	6. Spare chair	7. Gold stamp	8. Clock
1. Quietly curious	P041	P042	P043	P044	P045	P046	P047	P048
2. Ready for conversation	P049	P050	P051	P052	P053	P054	P055	P056
3. Willing to inspect a thing	P057	P058	P059	P060	P061	P062	P063	P064
4. Here for the atmosphere	P065	P066	P067	P068	P069	P070	P071	P072
5. Open to a wildcard	P073	P074	P075	P076	P077	P078	P079	P080

Local position = $8 \times (\text{row} - 1) + \text{emblem}$. Wrap modified position to 1-40. Global case = $40 \times (\text{department} - 1) + \text{local position}$.

AIDEN AND TANK / THE COALITION CHORUS

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A Coalition Cannot Pay You in Exposure

“Nigga, why is your chair listed as a vehicle?” Tank asked.

The hotel manager had delivered the financial statement in a folder thick enough to qualify as supporting furniture. We had found the agenda, recovered the pen, and agreed to discuss money before the evening grew any more ceremonial. I had responded by taking my seat in a mechanical photo throne. Its footrest extended into the exact place the catering staff needed to walk. Even my sitting down had logistical consequences.

“It's powered,” I explained. “So is a vacuum,” Rae said. “One of those would help.” She had returned from showing Nia her bike and looked unusually pleased with a discussion of brake cables. Nia looked pleased too. Neither had submitted a report. I respected their privacy by waiting almost twelve seconds before suggesting a commemorative photograph. Shawna squeezed my shoulder until my interest in documentation subsided.

The second room offered strategy games, card battles, long role-playing stories, and enough imaginary governments to support my worst instincts. I had printed place cards for ministries. Rae's said Practical Affairs. Kit's said Cultural Affairs. Nia's said Legal Affairs. Shawna looked at the last word and asked whether her ministry could be Private Affairs, beginning with my immediate removal from public office. I assured her my domestic portfolio remained exceptionally strong. “Your portfolio was late to its appointment,” she said. Tank studied the invoice harder, out of respect for a man dying in office.

Velvet put her actual contract beside the ministries. She had a costume rack, a rehearsed number, and a fee that didn't become less real because I called the evening a coalition. Remy wanted his microphone checked and his fanfare left gloriously ridiculous. Mercedes wanted her own set and recording arrangements honored. Porsche wanted nobody borrowing her equipment in exchange for gratitude. Rosa wanted staff time paid. Those were concrete requests. My request concerned being photographed beneath a large symbolic eagle nobody remembered approving.

Mika loved the eagle. “It would look incredible over the stage.” I pointed at them triumphantly. “But we don't have the rigging or the money,” they continued. The betrayal arrived with professional measurements. They put their tiny model hotel on the table and began using coins to represent possible costs. It was the first casino activity that had frightened me before anybody placed a bet.

June and Dez arrived carrying the Blue Comet folder. The jacket came too, over Dez's arm. June identified it as her asset before she sat down. Dez identified her alterations as a long-term investment. Their 1967 peace arrangement had apparently failed because each believed the other had refused to sign. Both now wanted the current summit to recognize their excellent record of reasonable behavior. I understood the emotional appeal of a committee certifying whatever story made you look best.

Nia declined to certify either veteran's entire life. She would help read the old paper during the break. For now she wanted clear terms for this evening and then freedom to be a guest. Rae

AIDEN AND TANK / THE COALITION CHORUS

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moved the good crackers within her reach without interrupting her sentence. Kit slid a lamp toward them, then reclaimed it an inch because she needed light on her own notes too. Nobody disappeared into service. Everybody kept a chair.

Dre sat down with his casserole and claimed the blue controller he'd brought. His Crip affiliation didn't make him my Minister of Blue Lighting, a position he declined before I finished explaining it. Darnell offered to underwrite entertainment from future yacht income. Velvet asked whether future money could arrive before present soundcheck. Darnell looked toward the bar, where his economic theory faced fewer follow-up questions.

I wanted to tell everyone that turn-based games meant a peaceful room. Shawna tapped the thick financial statement. "This waits while you think. Does it feel simple?" Fair. Waiting gave us time to understand decisions; it didn't remove the decisions. The useful game notes would remain plain, so a person could choose an appealing challenge without having me convert patience into a promise of ease.

I raised the ceremonial pen. Nia handed me an ordinary pencil. "Until we agree on the numbers." The mechanical chair lowered itself with a squeak that sounded expensive. Tank caught my glass. Rosa moved the catering trolley past my newly humbled knees. Nigga, the treasury had opened for business, and its first order was getting my ass out of the aisle.

AIDEN AND TANK / THE COALITION CHORUS

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P041 / READ THE CATCH FIRST

Sid Meier's Civilization VI

Edition considered: PC base game, no expansion requirement

Build a civilization whose cities, discoveries, and relationships reflect your decisions, gradually creating a history with a direction of your own.

What you do. Found a city, choose its production or research, and manage units, districts, policies, and relationships with neighboring powers over successive turns.

Mouse / pointer | Usually waits for choices | Co-op details need checking

Main catch. Solo turns allow deliberation, but menus and planning are heavy; test map gestures and readability rather than assuming cognitive simplicity.

Why it might click. Build a civilization across a large sweep of history, choosing how cities grow, what people research and how to deal with neighboring powers. The appeal is seeing many small decisions create a society with a recognizable direction rather than following one prescribed storyline.

The full catch. District placement, research, policies, diplomacy and multiple units produce heavy menu and planning demands. Single-player turns permit deliberation, but this is emphatically not cognitively simple because it is turn-based. Avoid assuming online turn settings match solo play; held map gestures and interface readability still need a trial.

Try this first. Use the guided opening or a modest single-player start to found one city and make one production choice. Judge whether the explanations make that decision interesting before opening an empire's worth of additional responsibilities.

Aiden's complete scene and the source notes follow on the next page.

AIDEN AND TANK / THE COALITION CHORUS

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P041 / THE COMIC SCENE AND SOURCES

Sid Meier's Civilization VI

AIDEN AT THE SUMMIT / The Capital Has Four Fountains and No Change

Civilization VI encouraged me to describe the summit budget as an emerging nation. I pointed at the four decorative fountains on the rental sheet. “Public infrastructure.”

Rosa pointed at the unpaid extra staff hours. “Public embarrassment.” Tank leaned over the page. “Nigga, your civilization discovered waterfalls before wages.”

Kit wanted one fountain moved away from her music stand because its cheerful gurgling competed with every quiet note. Rae wanted the same fountain emptied before somebody knocked it over beside the signing table.

I argued that capitals needed grandeur. Nia asked whether grandeur had a receipt we could cancel. Mika admitted the fountains looked beautiful, then identified two we could return without dismantling half the room.

June offered to name the remaining pair after herself and Dez. Dez said naming something after her didn't satisfy a debt, especially if it mostly leaked.

We returned two fountains. The staff line became payable. I announced the first reform of my administration. Shawna wrote CARRIED THE FOUNTAIN beside my name, which was historically precise and politically devastating.

Aiden's verdict. The empire-building scope can be rewarding when its planning appeals; waiting turns do not simplify it. Our capital has achieved payroll by reducing its unnecessary population of fountains.

Evidence desk / checked 20 September 2026

Exact base-game PC listing supports districts, research, policies and diplomacy. Waits refers to single-player turn decisions; complete input comfort and multiplayer timer/co-op configurations are not verified.

Source 1: <https://store.steampowered.com/app/289070/>

AIDEN AND TANK / THE COALITION CHORUS

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P042 / READ THE CATCH FIRST

Old World

Edition considered: PC base game

Guide a historical dynasty where aging rulers, competing families, and personal events give empire management a continuing story about people.

What you do. Read a ruler's decision, consider its personal consequences, and manage cities, resources, character roles, and court relationships as the dynasty develops.

Mouse / pointer | Usually waits for choices | Native co-op in this edition

Main catch. Untimed input is declared, but cities and family relationships form a dense strategy game; co-op setup needs separate checking.

Why it might click. Old World combines historical strategy with a living dynasty: rulers age, families compete, children grow and personal events affect the state. People and relationships can give empire management a more intimate story than a map of anonymous production totals.

The full catch. The developer declares play without timed input, a mouse-only option and saving at any time. That is encouraging for pacing, while court relationships, cities, resources and character roles still make this a dense strategy game. Declared co-op exists, but its setup and shared responsibilities require a separate check.

Try this first. Follow the introductory guidance until one ruler faces one clear decision. Read the affected person's name and consequence, then decide whether that personal layer makes the surrounding management enjoyable or merely adds another spreadsheet to remember.

Aiden's complete scene and the source notes follow on the next page.

AIDEN AND TANK / THE COALITION CHORUS

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P042 / THE COMIC SCENE AND SOURCES

Old World

AIDEN AT THE SUMMIT / The Dynasty Has Inherited a Cardigan

Old World's family politics made June argue that the Blue Comet jacket debt should be treated as a dynastic matter. Dez asked whether decades of alterations entitled her heirs to a sleeve.

"Your heirs can inherit the cardigan," June said. "My aunt liked that cardigan," Dez replied. "Then your aunt can adjudicate, nigga."

I offered to establish a hereditary Ministry of Restitution. Nia asked whether I intended to pay its salaries. Suddenly I admired a smaller government.

Rae examined the photograph of the original jacket. She liked the stitching across the shoulder. Dez began explaining how she'd altered it, and Kit leaned closer because she'd never seen a lining like that. June listened, pretending not to. When Dez described the final fitting, June remembered which song had been playing. They disagreed about the song but remembered the same ridiculous dance step.

Shawna touched my knee beneath the table. "That's a dynasty." I nodded like I understood, then offered to order a crest. "Nigga," she said, and the noble house survived without merchandise.

Aiden's verdict. The dynasty's personal events may make empire management attractive, with its dense systems understood. Our inherited claim concerns one jacket, one cardigan, and a remarkably durable shared memory.

Evidence desk / checked 20 September 2026

Exact listing supports dynasties/families and declares no timed input, Mouse Only Option, Save Anytime and co-op. Those declarations do not establish low menu load or a personally comfortable multiplayer arrangement.

Source 1: <https://store.steampowered.com/app/597180/>

AIDEN AND TANK / THE COALITION CHORUS

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P043 / READ THE CATCH FIRST

HUMANKIND

Edition considered: PC base game

Combine cultures across historical eras, shaping a civilization whose cities, conflicts, and achievements reflect an accumulating series of different choices.

What you do. Choose developments, manage resources and diplomacy, and make battlefield decisions while adapting the civilization to changes across successive historical eras.

Mouse / pointer | Usually waits for choices | Co-op details need checking

Main catch. Empire and battlefield systems overlap, making memory demands high; solo turns do not establish relaxed settings in every configuration.

Why it might click. Shape a civilization by combining cultures across eras rather than staying with a single identity throughout history. City growth, fame and tactical conflicts turn the map into an account of accumulated decisions, including choices about what kind of achievements matter.

The full catch. Empire management and battlefield decisions sit on top of one another. Culture transitions add systems to learn, while resources, diplomacy and competing goals make the memory load high. Turn-based battles do not establish a universally simple control scheme or relaxed multiplayer timer settings; begin with solo play and inspect menus.

Try this first. Follow the early guidance through one development choice and read what it changes. Stop to decide whether comparing those possibilities feels engaging before treating the next historical era as an obligation to keep playing.

Aiden's complete scene and the source notes follow on the next page.

AIDEN AND TANK / THE COALITION CHORUS

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P043 / THE COMIC SCENE AND SOURCES

HUMANKIND

AIDEN AT THE SUMMIT / The Ministry Has Changed Its Outfit Again

HUMANKIND's changing cultures inspired my declaration that the summit could evolve beyond its first identity. Velvet looked at my new ceremonial jacket. "You mean your fourth outfit."

"Adaptation." "Dry-cleaning liability."

Mika wanted to move from welcome mode to actual evening mode. Kit wanted the stage colors changed for karaoke. Rae wanted the budget to recognize that good snacks remained good snacks regardless of historical era.

June said the Blue Comet had reinvented itself three times in one summer. Dez remembered the same jukebox in every version. "New sign. Same nigga hogging the buttons." June smiled proudly, taking this as evidence of continuity.

Nia revised the proposed ministries into temporary jobs with specific endings. Velvet became the person approving her own costume handling. Rosa retained catering authority because she'd already been doing it successfully.

I asked what I became. Shawna held up the jacket bag. "A husband who can put his old clothes away." My civilization entered a new era carrying its previous era over one arm.

Aiden's verdict. The changing-culture structure offers a distinctive historical strategy, with its management burden intact. Our summit's latest era has replaced ceremonial titles with jobs that end when their work does.

Evidence desk / checked 20 September 2026

Publisher listing supports combining cultures, fame and turn-based tactical battles. Pacing label applies to solo strategic decisions; complete holds, map controls and multiplayer configurations remain unchecked.

Source 1: <https://store.steampowered.com/app/1124300/>

AIDEN AND TANK / THE COALITION CHORUS

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P044 / A PLACE TO START

Into the Breach

Edition considered: PC Advanced Edition update

Solve small mech battles by reading enemy attacks in advance, finding a move that changes several threats through clever positioning.

What you do. Inspect the next announced attack, identify threatened squares, and move or act with a mech to change what will happen.

Mouse / pointer | Usually waits for choices | Single-player; a friend can share the decisions

Main catch. The small board still demands spatial reasoning and limited-action planning; selection controls need testing, and failure changes a run.

Why it might click. Small mech battles become visible tactical puzzles because enemy attacks are telegraphed before the next turn. The pleasure is finding an unexpected move that changes several threats at once, often by shifting positions rather than simply choosing the strongest attack.

The full catch. A compact board can still ask for demanding spatial reasoning. Protecting buildings, understanding attack direction and managing limited actions are central, and failure changes a run. The turn structure supports thought before acting; it does not prove every menu or selection gesture suits the player. Advanced Edition adds more systems.

Try this first. Try the opening guidance and inspect one announced enemy attack before choosing a move. Say which square is threatened and what one action changes; there is no need to solve the entire campaign to test that central pleasure.

Aiden's complete scene and the source notes follow on the next page.

AIDEN AND TANK / THE COALITION CHORUS

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P044 / THE COMIC SCENE AND SOURCES

Into the Breach

AIDEN AT THE SUMMIT / The Mech Has Moved the Dessert Table

Into the Breach showed attacks before they landed. I wished the hotel did that with invoices. Mika pointed out that the rental company had sent me six clear estimates.

“Nigga, those were telegraphed,” Tank said. “You ignored the telegram.”

Rosa needed a path from the kitchen. Remy's costume trunk occupied one square, Kit's lamp another, and my ceremonial chair occupied enough territory to govern itself.

Rae sketched the room on a napkin. One move: chair against the wall. Another: trunk beside the stage. Suddenly the dessert trolley could pass without threatening a crown or a kneecap.

Mika liked the rearrangement so much they added a tiny model chair to their miniature hotel. Kit objected that the real lamp's new angle improved Velvet's entrance more than hers. Velvet offered to trade the angle after her show.

I attempted to move my chair with dignity. Its wheels squeaked through the entire negotiation. Shawna followed carrying my abandoned sash. The giant machine in this battle was my fucking furniture.

Aiden's verdict. The visible tactical problems may appeal to careful planning, while the practical notes govern the trial. Our napkin battle succeeded by relocating one oversized chair instead of buying another solution.

Evidence desk / checked 20 September 2026

Publisher describes minimalistic turn-based combat with telegraphed attacks; current PC includes Advanced Edition content. Waits reflects tactical decision structure, not a complete no-hold/comfort certification.

Source 1: <https://store.steampowered.com/app/590380/>

AIDEN AND TANK / THE COALITION CHORUS

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P045 / READ THE CATCH FIRST

Wargroove

Edition considered: PC base game

Lead a displaced queen's bright fantasy campaign, using distinctive commanders and varied terrain to make positioning and resource choices matter.

What you do. Follow campaign instructions, select units on the map, and choose movement or attacks while managing funds and different army roles.

Mixed controls | Usually waits for choices | Native co-op in this edition

Main catch. Army funds and unit matchups require learning; exact co-op coverage, timing settings, and selection gestures need their own check.

Why it might click. Wargroove gives turn-based army battles a bright fantasy cast and a campaign about a displaced queen seeking allies. Commanders have distinctive special abilities, while different units and terrain make each map a problem about positioning and resource choices.

The full catch. Managing an army, its funds and its unit matchups is more involved than moving one character. The editor and multiplayer add separate layers rather than simplifying the campaign. Co-op is listed, but exact campaign coverage and setup should be checked; no untimed or hold-free claim applies automatically to every configuration.

Try this first. Start with the campaign's opening instruction and command one unit through one explained action. Test the map selection interface and the clarity of the unit information before recruiting a large army or opening the editor.

Aiden's complete scene and the source notes follow on the next page.

AIDEN AND TANK / THE COALITION CHORUS

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P045 / THE COMIC SCENE AND SOURCES

Wargroove

AIDEN AT THE SUMMIT / The Displaced Queen Has a Better Fanfare

Wargroove's displaced queen needed allies. Velvet needed the electrical socket beneath my ceremonial chair. I considered these parallel struggles and offered a formal alliance.

She pointed. "Move your throne, nigga." Diplomacy was becoming terribly specific.

Remy proposed a joint entrance with his fanfare leading into her number. Kit challenged the key. Mercedes tested the transition at the piano while the rest of us waited to discover whether monarchy could hear pitch.

It actually worked. Remy looked delighted. Velvet adjusted one note, he adjusted his bow, and the alliance gained a musical border neither objected to.

Rae moved the extension cable away from the signing table. Nia held it clear while she worked. I offered strategic commentary until Shawna asked me to be the infantry carrying the chair.

We parked it against the wall. June sat in it instantly. "Better than the Blue Comet chairs." Dez asked whether she'd borrowed this one too. The queen had been restored, but the historic opposition retained its seat directly beside her.

Aiden's verdict. The fantasy campaign and commander personalities can make tactics appealing, with unit and interface demands retained. Our musical alliance found its socket by expelling the host's throne from useful territory.

Evidence desk / checked 20 September 2026

Exact PC listing supports turn-based campaign, commander Grooves and native co-op categories. Co-op mode scope is not assumed to cover the whole main campaign; complete input demands are unchecked.

Source 1: <https://store.steampowered.com/app/607050/>

AIDEN AND TANK / THE COALITION CHORUS

Niggas, games up.

Niggas, pens out.

Niggas, chairs in.

Niggas, snacks here.

Niggas, receipts ready.

Niggas, lights on.

Niggas, mic check.

Niggas, take turns.

Niggas, dance later.

Niggas, read first.

Niggas, pick freely.

Niggas, no rush.

Niggas, sign here.

Niggas, stay petty.

Niggas, we're good.

P046 / READ THE CATCH FIRST

Wargroove 2

Edition considered: PC base game

Return to colorful army tactics through linked campaigns, new commanders, and a conflict over forbidden technology in an expanding fantasy world.

What you do. Read a commander's ability, move units, and use battlefield actions while learning the revised Groove system through the initial campaign.

Mixed controls | Usually waits for choices | Native co-op in this edition

Main catch. New abilities add knowledge to army management; extra modes and listed co-op do not automatically simplify campaign play.

Why it might click. The sequel builds a new conflict around forbidden technology and several connected campaigns, with new commanders and a revised Groove system. Its attraction is returning to colorful map tactics with fresh factions, tactical possibilities and a continuing fantasy world.

The full catch. New commander abilities and linked campaigns add knowledge to the familiar army-management demands. The separate Conquest mode and editing tools are optional avenues, not recommended first steps here. Native co-op is listed, but campaign coverage, timing settings and comfortable selection controls need their own verification.

Try this first. Take the initial campaign instruction one action at a time and read one commander's ability carefully. Compare that single mechanic with ordinary movement before exploring extra modes or designing an ambitious custom scenario for everyone else.

Aiden's complete scene and the source notes follow on the next page.

AIDEN AND TANK / THE COALITION CHORUS

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P046 / THE COMIC SCENE AND SOURCES

Wargroove 2

AIDEN AT THE SUMMIT / Forbidden Technology Is a Jukebox with Bluetooth

Wargroove 2's forbidden technology led June to inspect the wireless music tablet with suspicion. She wanted her Blue Comet song queued. Dez wanted evidence that it would play only once.

I offered a password-protected accord. Mika said we could simply put the song in the set list. My treaty provisions were losing to buttons again.

Remy asked whether his revised fanfare counted as new technology. Velvet said it counted as a persistent condition. He played the opening anyway, softer, and she smiled before she could stop herself.

Kit wanted a clean transition into karaoke. Mercedes wrote the order on a card: song, number, break, karaoke. Four lines resolved a conflict I had planned to announce beneath a projection of crossed swords.

June approved until she saw her song appeared only once. Dez tapped the card. "Reparations begin with restraint, nigga."

I quietly deleted the crossed swords from the slideshow. Mika caught me, then admitted they looked excellent. We saved them for an optional photograph, where forbidden technology could harm only my dignity.

Aiden's verdict. The sequel adds factions and abilities to an already tactical structure; those additions still require learning. Our forbidden jukebox technology has been restrained by a four-line card and Dez's finger.

Evidence desk / checked 20 September 2026

Current publisher listing supports three campaigns, revised Grooves, Conquest and native co-op. Waits refers to turn-based tactics, not an all-modes or hold-free guarantee.

Source 1: <https://store.steampowered.com/app/1346020/>

AIDEN AND TANK / THE COALITION CHORUS

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P047 / READ THE CATCH FIRST

Advance Wars 1+2: Re-Boot Camp

Edition considered: Nintendo Switch compilation

Explore rebuilt Advance Wars campaigns where colorful commanding officers and land, sea, and air units turn terrain into a tactical puzzle.

What you do. Follow training, inspect a unit's information, and choose movement, capture, or attack decisions while managing different battlefield roles and funds.

Direction + buttons | Usually waits for choices | Co-op details need checking

Main catch. Ranges, funds, and mission conditions still demand planning; versus multiplayer does not establish a shared campaign or comfortable controls.

Why it might click. This Switch collection rebuilds the first two Advance Wars campaigns around colorful land, sea and air battles. Commanding officers bring personalities and special powers, while terrain, capture decisions and different unit roles provide a board-game-like tactical focus.

The full catch. Bright presentation does not remove the need to compare ranges, terrain, funds and matchups. It is turn-based, but particular mission conditions can still create strategic urgency. Nintendo's listed multiplayer includes versus play; do not assume a shared campaign. Hold behavior and readability require a check on the actual display.

Try this first. Follow the early training and move one unit using its displayed information. Check whether the explanation makes its purpose clear before progressing to a larger force with several different roles to remember at once.

Aiden's complete scene and the source notes follow on the next page.

AIDEN AND TANK / THE COALITION CHORUS

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P047 / THE COMIC SCENE AND SOURCES

Advance Wars 1+2: Re-Boot Camp

AIDEN AT THE SUMMIT / The Land, Sea, and Air Budgets Are Mostly Snacks

Advance Wars gave me three branches for our imaginary ministries. Land would cover seating. Sea would cover drinks. Air would cover the chandelier rental. Nia waited until I finished admiring the symmetry.

“Where are the performers?” “Culture.” “You’ve invented a fourth ministry to avoid paying the first three correctly.”

Tank volunteered for Sea and immediately requested a water refill. Rae claimed Land long enough to reject the decorative chairs nobody could sit on. Kit asked whether Air included stage lighting or just my emotional atmosphere.

Mika drew three columns on a sheet and wrote actual costs beneath them. The chandeliers overwhelmed their branch before the first skirmish. I tried declaring emergency powers.

Shawna vetoed the phrase emergency powers. Velvet seconded her. Remy played a tiny defeat sound, then apologized to the sound for being too effective.

We abandoned the ministries and kept Mika’s cost columns. Nigga, my armed forces had dissolved into an ordinary budget, leaving the admiral holding two glasses of water and a very good sandwich.

Aiden’s verdict. The colorful tactical collection offers commanding personalities and varied battles, with planning and controls still to assess. Our three service branches have achieved hydration and surrendered their ceremonial titles.

Evidence desk / checked 20 September 2026

Nintendo identifies the Switch remake collection and turn-based land/sea/air tactics, terrain and CO powers. Versus multiplayer is confirmed; native campaign co-op is not established. No complete no-hold guarantee.

Source 1: <https://www.nintendo.com/us/store/products/advance-wars-1-plus-2-re-boot-camp-switch/>

AIDEN AND TANK / THE COALITION CHORUS

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P048 / READ THE CATCH FIRST

Fire Emblem: Three Houses

Edition considered: Nintendo Switch base game

Choose a house of characters to know over a long story, where relationships develop alongside tactical battles and a continent's political crisis.

What you do. Talk with the cast, manage lessons and equipment, explore the monastery, and command units through tactical battles in the chosen house's story.

Mixed controls | Some real-time demands | Single-player; a friend can share the decisions

Main catch. Normal/Casual reduces losses, but schedules and menus remain heavy; monastery movement adds a separate camera-control question.

Why it might click. A teacher's relationship with students develops alongside tactical battles and a continent's political crisis. Choosing a house gives the long story a particular group to know, making friendships, loyalties and changing circumstances a substantial part of the experience.

The full catch. Normal difficulty with Casual mode revives fallen allies after battles, but it does not remove lessons, schedules, equipment or tactical menus. Monastery exploration adds three-dimensional movement and camera considerations. This is a rich character game with heavy management demands, not a simple visual novel because conversations are prominent.

Try this first. Choose Normal and Casual for the first trial, then assess one introductory battle explanation and one conversation. Test monastery movement separately when available; comfort with selecting a battle square does not answer the camera question.

Aiden's complete scene and the source notes follow on the next page.

AIDEN AND TANK / THE COALITION CHORUS

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P048 / THE COMIC SCENE AND SOURCES

Fire Emblem: Three Houses

AIDEN AT THE SUMMIT / Three Houses and None of Them Owns the Extension Cord

Three Houses prompted me to divide the evening into noble houses. I gave Kit, Rae, and Velvet each a colored ribbon. Nia immediately asked which one she should wear.

“Whichever represents you.” “Several, Aiden.” “Then take several.” She did. My elegant taxonomy looked like a gift-wrapping accident within thirty seconds.

Remy wanted a crown on his ribbon. Mika wanted the colors to match the actual room map. Rosa asked whether the ribbons were washable because one had already landed in sauce.

Kit tied hers around a lamp so nobody borrowed it during rehearsal. Rae used hers to mark the repaired table leg. Velvet added hers to a costume where it looked intentional and expensive.

June said every house in 1967 had shared one extension cord. Dez corrected her: it belonged to Dez, and June had returned a lamp cord without a plug.

I removed the houses from the budget. Shawna kept one ribbon around my wrist. “So I can identify my wandering investment, nigga.”

Aiden’s verdict. The long character story has appeal alongside tactical battles, while schedules, menus, and hub controls remain substantial. Our noble houses immediately became ribbons serving more useful purposes than classification.

Evidence desk / checked 20 September 2026

Nintendo confirms turn-based battles, academy exploration/calendar and Normal/Casual options. Casual removes permanent allied losses in battle, not other complexity. Whole-path hold/camera comfort remains untested.

Source 1: <https://www.nintendo.com/en-gb/Games/Nintendo-Switch-games/Fire-Emblem-Three-Houses-1175482.html>

AIDEN AND TANK / THE COALITION CHORUS

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P049 / READ THE CATCH FIRST

Fire Emblem Engage

Edition considered: Nintendo Switch base game

Experiment with character and Emblem pairings in colorful tactical battles, discovering how different strengths change the options available on the grid.

What you do. Read unit matchups, select battle actions, and develop characters through weapons, rings, skills, and pairings with legendary Emblems as the campaign progresses.

Mixed controls | Some real-time demands | Co-op details need checking

Main catch. Normal/Casual and other aids change punishment or support decisions; they do not establish low menu load or comfortable hub movement.

Why it might click. Engage emphasizes colorful tactical battles and the abilities gained by pairing characters with legendary Emblems. The appeal is experimenting with a cast's different strengths and seeing how a chosen pairing changes the possibilities on a grid-based battlefield.

The full catch. Weapon relationships, rings, skills and party development create many interlocking rules. Nintendo confirms Normal difficulty, Casual mode and Auto-Battle, plus a limited rewind system. Those aids change punishment or decision support; they do not prove low menu load or comfortable movement around the hub.

Try this first. Use Normal and Casual, read one unit's weapon matchup, and try its basic action before exploring every ring combination. Examine Auto-Battle as an optional tool only after seeing what it controls, keeping the choice to participate or delegate yours.

Aiden's complete scene and the source notes follow on the next page.

AIDEN AND TANK / THE COALITION CHORUS

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P049 / THE COMIC SCENE AND SOURCES

Fire Emblem Engage

AIDEN AT THE SUMMIT / The Emblem Is a Sticker on My Wallet

Fire Emblem Engage made Remy ask whether our imaginary ministries could pair with legendary patrons. I said everyone could benefit from my sponsorship. Velvet placed a glittering sticker on my wallet.

“There. Legendary funding.”

Kit paired with Mercedes for an entrance-music arrangement. Rae paired with the hotel technician to stop a second table wobbling. Nia paired with a glass of wine and explicitly declared herself off duty for ten minutes.

I asked who wanted the Aiden emblem. Tank raised his hand, took my wallet, and paid the delivery man for the extra good crackers. My power activated immediately and with alarming efficiency.

June wanted a commemorative sticker for surviving both Blue Comet wars. Dez wanted one for surviving June. Remy made both by hand and gave them matching crowns.

Shawna recovered my wallet before I could sponsor a commemorative sticker kiosk. She peeled the glitter from the leather and pressed it onto my jacket. “There, baby. You can feel powerful without opening anything.”

Aiden’s verdict. The character pairings give this tactical adventure a distinct attraction, with its systems and movement questions retained. My legendary emblem currently grants allies access to the cracker budget.

Evidence desk / checked 20 September 2026

Nintendo supports grid tactics, Emblem pairings, Normal/Casual, Auto-Battle and limited rewind. No full-path hold/camera assurance or shared campaign is inferred; multiplayer scope remains unverified here.

Source 1: <https://www.nintendo.com/en-gb/Games/Nintendo-Switch-games/Fire-Emblem-Engage-2267157.html>

AIDEN AND TANK / THE COALITION CHORUS				
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P050 / READ THE CATCH FIRST

Mario + Rabbids Kingdom Battle

Edition considered: Nintendo Switch base game

Join Mario characters and Rabbids in comic tactical battles, where their different roles make cover, positioning, and coordinated attacks worth learning.

What you do. Follow a solo battle explanation, compare movement with an attack, and learn exploration, equipment, and abilities as the adventure continues.

Mixed controls | Some real-time demands | Native co-op in this edition

Main catch. Local co-op covers separate challenges, not the full campaign; navigation and controls need checking without assuming the sequel's accommodations.

Why it might click. Mario characters and Rabbids join forces in colorful tactical battles, with each hero contributing a different role. The mismatch between earnest adventure and Rabbid behavior offers a comic frame for learning positioning, cover and coordinated attacks.

The full catch. Combat takes turns, but exploration, equipment and abilities still require learning and navigation. Nintendo describes local co-op as additional challenges, not the entire story campaign. Do not infer the sequel's hold toggles or other accommodations for this first game; exact gesture and camera comfort need checking.

Try this first. Follow an early solo battle explanation and compare one movement option with one attack. If playing together is the main attraction, inspect the separate co-op challenges and their requirements rather than promising shared control of the whole campaign.

Aiden's complete scene and the source notes follow on the next page.

AIDEN AND TANK / THE COALITION CHORUS

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P050 / THE COMIC SCENE AND SOURCES

Mario + Rabbids Kingdom Battle

AIDEN AT THE SUMMIT / The Rabbids Have Applied for Cabinet Positions

Mario and the Rabbids formed an unlikely tactical team. Our summit's unlikely team was Kit and Tank, who wanted the same stage platform for completely different reasons.

Kit wanted height for karaoke. Tank wanted to see whether the buffet had been replenished without standing. "Strategic awareness," he said. Nigga had studied my vocabulary too well.

Rae inspected the platform and found it sturdy. Mika pointed out that moving it now would delay Velvet's rehearsal. A compromise formed: Kit could use it later, Tank could use his legs immediately.

Tank objected to the burden placed on the Ministry of Appetite. Rosa held up a fresh tray. The minister crossed the room at impressive speed.

Remy climbed onto the platform and tried a heroic pose. His crown tilted into one eye. Velvet straightened it, kissed his cheek, and asked him to stop dying before the opening number.

I proposed making them co-chairs. Shawna said we already had too many chairs and the next title would incur a storage fee.

Aiden's verdict. The mismatched cast gives the tactics a comic frame; the separate co-op challenges are not the campaign. Our unlikely coalition has resolved its platform dispute through the attraction of hot food.

Evidence desk / checked 20 September 2026

Nintendo confirms turn-based combat and separate local co-op challenges. Co-op flag is restricted to those challenges; no whole-campaign co-op or Sparks of Hope control options are transferred.

Source 1: <https://www.nintendo.com/us/store/products/mario-plus-rabbids-kingdom-battle-switch/>

Source 2: <https://play.nintendo.com/news-tips/game-releases/mario-rabbids-kingdom-battle-release-date/>

AIDEN AND TANK / THE COALITION CHORUS

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Both Sides of the Paper and Who Gets Paid to Hold It

Nia unfolded the old Blue Comet invoice during the break. June pointed at the front. “My signature. The other party refused.” Dez turned it over. “My signature. The other party refused.” Nobody spoke for three beautiful seconds. Then Tank put his face in his hands.

“Niggas. Turn the fucking paper over.”

They had each spent fifty-nine years looking at the surface that supported their argument. June had signed the hall charge. Dez had signed the peace terms on the reverse. Both signatures were there, along with alternating jukebox selections, return of June's jacket before winter, and two ginger ales that had survived every retelling by remaining unmentioned.

I reached for my phone to photograph the breakthrough. Shawna said I could ask first. Both veterans agreed, provided I kept the picture out of any slideshow containing my face. Apparently they'd read the conditions of my hospitality more carefully than their own peace agreement.

June studied the jacket clause. Dez studied the ginger ales. Each had located a different obstacle to victory. Remy offered a two-sided fanfare. Velvet put a hand over his keyboard. “Let these women experience the silence, baby. They paid fifty-nine years for it.”

The present-day hotel invoice waited beside the historical one. Kit had found a duplicate lamp charge. Rae had found a labor line that assumed she'd remain available to repair furniture all evening. Nia had found herself listed as legal support through midnight. None of those entries had been agreed with the people whose time they described.

I said the hotel must have misunderstood. Rae turned the page toward me. The note read PER HOST REQUEST. My handwriting, for once, was entirely legible.

“Nigga, you can't call my hands a resource before you ask whether they're free.”

I began explaining that I'd meant available in case something went wrong. “Something already went wrong,” she said. “You spent my evening.” Her voice was sharper than it had been over the crackers, and it should have been. This wasn't a preference about olives. I had given somebody else a claim on her time because she had been helpful in front of me.

Kit said she could take some of the work. Rae shook her head. “The work isn't yours to redistribute either. Start with the assumption that I came to play.”

I saw Nia close her folder. She'd been trying to do that for twenty minutes. I had interpreted each new useful answer as an invitation to produce another question. A free lawyer was becoming one of my favorite features of the room, which was an ugly way to think about a woman who had come partly because she liked the mechanic sitting beside her.

I crossed out both assignments. The correction didn't make the earlier presumption clever. Nia kept the folder closed and said she would join the rest of the conversation as a person, which I considered a remarkably modest demand under the circumstances.

The sponsor approached before we could enjoy our breakthrough. He wanted a photograph with the coalition's respectable leadership before the performers changed into their show clothes. He

AIDEN AND TANK / THE COALITION CHORUS

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nodded toward Kit and me, then looked at Velvet's headpiece as though it might damage his insurance.

Kit asked what he meant by respectable. He said polished, professional, welcoming to everyone. Velvet lifted her payment schedule. "I'm a professional. Welcoming everyone is already in the room. Which part of my head costs you customers?"

The man laughed because he wanted it to be a joke. It wasn't only a joke. Remy stood beside her in ordinary clothes, crown in hand, waiting to learn which version of him the sponsor considered sellable. Nobody at the table had volunteered to become the decorative proof that money could get along with difference if difference selected a quieter outfit.

I offered to take the photograph later. Shawna looked at me. "Later with whom?" I had tried delaying the choice without changing it. My skill at mediation often consisted of moving a bad sentence ten minutes into the future and hoping nobody followed.

The sponsor left to take a call. Kit exhaled. "I could do the picture and insist the show stays exactly as planned. It might keep the money uncomplicated."

Rae looked at her. "Uncomplicated for whom?"

Kit was tired of that question, which didn't make it the wrong one. "For the people getting paid. Sometimes I've kept a library event alive by letting a donor feel like the room looked familiar. I'm not proud of every conversation. I also don't want the performers losing a fee because I chose the cleanest speech."

Kit looked at me before continuing. "And don't decide the person who can write a check is the bravest one here. My library hours got cut. I can't replace a lost fee out of my account. That affects what risks feel available." I had been preparing a generous expression; it became uncomfortable on my face. Rae nodded. "I believe you. It still matters whose face the sponsor chose for professional." Kit said yes, both things mattered. Neither sentence paid the fee. We still had to find the money, and my advantages were about to become useful only if I stopped treating them as a superior moral personality.

Velvet nodded once. "That's a real problem. Here's my real answer: ask me before you purchase my survival with a smaller version of me." She wasn't rejecting every negotiation. She wanted the person whose work was being negotiated to exist inside it. "I can choose an outfit for a client. I can also say the client's request costs more than the booking's worth. Don't make that choice and hand me the money like you rescued me."

Remy said the sponsor had called his act surprisingly tasteful. "I know what he meant. I also know my act contains a pun about a royal accountant getting double-entry heartbreak. Tasteful wasn't a review. It was relief."

Velvet laughed despite herself. "That joke is so fucking bad." "And yet it belongs to me." He put his crown on, crooked again. She left it crooked for once.

Rae described the hotel entrance earlier: Kit received a question about lighting, Rae received directions for contractors. Kit had initially explained the difference away because she hadn't wanted the room to become unpleasant before the party started. "I made the pleasant version

AIDEN AND TANK / THE COALITION CHORUS

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more important than the thing you said happened,” Kit said now. Rae nodded. She didn't make Kit perform an apology twice just to prolong the advantage.

June leaned forward. “Money doesn't ask all of us to become respectable in the same way. But don't use that sentence to tell me I've never wanted a nice suit or a calm evening. I like both. This suit is beautiful.” Dez touched her sleeve. “It is. And this time it's actually on its owner.”

June let the laugh settle. “I've swallowed things at work to keep wages coming. I've also said no and worried afterward. I don't need my younger self put on trial by people who got to read the ending before deciding what she'd do.” She looked at me. “Your room needs choices. It doesn't need a purity competition sponsored by your wallet.”

I had been quietly imagining myself funding a perfect space where none of this occurred. That fantasy flattered the payer. It also made every complication somebody else's failure to appreciate the gift. I could rent chairs. I could pay staff. I couldn't make a Black woman's account of what happened at the door unnecessary just by paying for a nicer door.

Nia asked whether we could keep two questions visible: what immediate arrangement a person chose, and what conditions made the choice expensive. “I don't want my own compromises used to tell the next person they're obligated to make them. I also don't want a room full of spectators grading whether I resisted attractively enough.” Then she opened her hands. “That's my contribution. Somebody else can type it if they want it remembered.”

Mika typed. They also admitted they'd nearly accepted the sponsor's photograph request because they wanted the event to start and the room to look successful. “A beautiful room can photograph a problem out of existence,” they said. “I'm very good at that. I'd like to be good at knowing when I'm doing it.”

Kit asked about putting the cost somewhere visible. What would it take to keep the promised fees independent of the sponsor's flattering photograph? This time she asked Velvet first. Velvet named the amount already contracted, not a moral price. Rosa named the staffing balance. The hotel manager confirmed which duplicate and unopened rentals could be refunded. Numbers replaced the vague threat that honesty would bankrupt the evening.

Darnell arrived asking whether his party supplies qualified as entertainment expense. Tank glanced at the bag he'd been carrying. “Your cocaine is not a coalition department, nigga.” Darnell took it away and returned with a plate, where his contribution could remain the size of his appetite. We did not need his procurement story to understand the difference between an agreed fee and a personal decision.

AIDEN AND TANK / THE COALITION CHORUS

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Niggas, pick freely.	Niggas, no rush.	Niggas, sign here.	Niggas, stay petty.	Niggas, we're good.

I covered the contracted shortfall, approved the refunds, and told the sponsor the photograph would include whoever independently wanted to be in it. Nobody owed a performance of gratitude. He could choose whether he wanted the photograph on those terms. The room did not instantly become just. It became a room where one particular leverage attempt had failed without its target losing her fee.

Kit kept the duplicate-charge note. Rae kept her evening. Nia stayed seated instead of reopening the folder. June and Dez requested copies of both sides of their invoice and agreed to split the ancient ginger-ale debt symbolically over dinner. No interest. No tribunal. No commemorative eagle.

I offered the eagle at a discount. Shawna kissed my cheek, took my pencil, and said, “The survivors have suffered enough.” Then she asked me to dance later as her husband, without representing any ministry. Nigga, I accepted before somebody could turn the offer into a job description.

AIDEN AND TANK / THE COALITION CHORUS

Niggas, games up.	Niggas, pens out.	Niggas, chairs in.	Niggas, snacks here.	Niggas, receipts ready.
Niggas, lights on.	Niggas, mic check.	Niggas, take turns.	Niggas, dance later.	Niggas, read first.
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P051 / READ THE CATCH FIRST

Mario + Rabbids Sparks of Hope

Edition considered: Nintendo Switch base game

Travel between imaginative planets with Mario and the Rabbids, combining heroes with Sparks while their antics give each new place comic appeal.

What you do. Explore with direct movement, inspect control options, and choose hero abilities or battle actions while learning how movement-based techniques work.

Mixed controls | Some real-time demands | Single-player; a friend can share the decisions

Main catch. Useful control options exist, but camera, direct movement, and traversal still need testing; the first game's co-op does not transfer.

Why it might click. Mario and the Rabbids travel between imaginative planets, meeting odd characters and combining heroes with helpful Sparks. Tactical battles sit inside a larger exploratory adventure, with the cast's antics providing a light comic reason to see what the next place contains.

The full catch. Ubisoft documents specific hold toggles, single-press alternatives, camera adjustments, automatic skill management and invulnerability. These are real options, not proof of a wholly no-rush path: direct movement, camera handling and airborne or traversal actions need checking. The first game's co-op challenges do not establish co-op here.

Try this first. Inspect those control options before play, then test ordinary movement and a first battle at the preferred difficulty. Check how a team jump or other moving action feels when introduced; stop there if the practical demands outweigh the appeal.

Aiden's complete scene and the source notes follow on the next page.

AIDEN AND TANK / THE COALITION CHORUS

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P051 / THE COMIC SCENE AND SOURCES

Mario + Rabbids Sparks of Hope

AIDEN AT THE SUMMIT / The Planet of Unpaid Balloons

Sparks of Hope sent its cast between imaginative planets. I had ordered three balloon planets to float over our budget table, each labeled with a proposed fund. The largest was HOST'S DISCRETION.

Rae turned it around. "This nigga gave himself Jupiter." Nia laughed so suddenly her wine nearly joined the solar system.

Mika loved the planets and refused to let me claim their defense as support for the labels. They peeled off HOST'S DISCRETION and replaced it with an actual estimate of the remaining room charge.

The label barely fit. Kit requested a smaller planet for stage lighting. Velvet asked whether her fee had become a moon because she preferred money that didn't orbit somebody else's priorities.

Remy found a marker and drew a crown on the nearest tiny satellite. June and Dez argued about who had discovered the planet of borrowed jackets first.

Shawna cut the string to my enormous balloon and handed it to me. "Hold your discretionary spending." Nigga, I spent the entire discussion physically attached to a bad decision.

Aiden's verdict. The colorful planetary journey has comic appeal, with movement, camera, and update details still important. Our budget's largest planet is currently tethered to the man who named it after himself.

Evidence desk / checked 20 September 2026

Developer UX interview documents listed options and time to think during turns; publisher article confirms direct real-time movement. These do not verify every traversal sequence. Single-player sequel assessed separately from Kingdom Battle.

Source 1:

<https://news.ubisoft.com/en-gb/article/3geL8lbYETmgHk6W017HpS/mario-rabbids-sparks-of-hope-accessibility-spotlight>

Source 2: <https://news.ubisoft.com/en-us/article/65J7B5ga4HkMpXtYWQ7QX5>

AIDEN AND TANK / THE COALITION CHORUS

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P052 / READ THE CATCH FIRST

XCOM: Enemy Unknown

Edition considered: PC base game; not Enemy Within expansion

Build Earth's defense against an alien invasion, growing attached to soldiers whose battlefield decisions connect to research, equipment, and headquarters planning.

What you do. Move soldiers into cover, choose explained combat actions, and manage research, budgets, equipment, and base decisions between ground missions.

Mixed controls | Some real-time demands | Single-player; a friend can share the decisions

Main catch. Multiple soldiers and base systems add weight; casualties create pressure, and complete interception or held-input behavior is not audited.

Why it might click. Lead a defense organization against an alien invasion, growing attached to soldiers while choosing research, equipment and battlefield tactics. The appeal is the connection between a strategic headquarters and the small, consequential decisions made by a squad on the ground.

The full catch. Turn-based ground combat still involves cover, ranges, hit chances and multiple soldiers. Research, budgets and base decisions add another layer, while casualties and global threats create pressure. This card is Enemy Unknown without assuming Enemy Within additions; complete interception, timing and held-input behavior has not been audited.

Try this first. Use the opening tutorial and focus on one soldier's move into cover and one explained action. Assess whether the battlefield information feels interesting before treating the larger base-management system as part of an evening's commitment.

Aiden's complete scene and the source notes follow on the next page.

AIDEN AND TANK / THE COALITION CHORUS

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P052 / THE COMIC SCENE AND SOURCES

XCOM: Enemy Unknown

AIDEN AT THE SUMMIT / The Alien Invasion Has a Delivery Window

XCOM's headquarters needed research, equipment, and people ready for a crisis. Our headquarters received a delivery marked EXTRATERRESTRIAL WELCOME EFFECT. I asked the driver whether he had the correct room.

He showed me my signature. Tank said, "Nigga, the aliens know who summoned them."

Inside were silver inflatable creatures intended for the entrance. Kit wanted one behind the karaoke stage. Mika wanted all three above the registration desk. Rae wanted to know whether either improvement was worth the charge.

Nia asked which items could still be returned. The driver pointed to the unopened boxes. Everyone looked at the creature I had already inflated halfway while pretending to investigate it.

Shawna let the air out. The alien collapsed slowly against my chest, an intimate portrait of fiscal surrender. Velvet photographed only after asking, and I agreed because it was admittedly excellent.

We kept one for the show and returned two. The invasion was contained. Its surviving diplomat received a feather boa and a supporting role, neither authorized by its home planet.

Aiden's verdict. The connection between headquarters and soldiers can create compelling stakes, with broad management demands retained. Our alien emergency was resolved through unopened packaging and one surprisingly employable silver visitor.

Evidence desk / checked 20 September 2026

Base-game listing supports turn-based squad combat, base/research management and interceptions. Pacing is mixed because the full strategic/interception loop is not certified wholly untimed. No expansion feature is assumed.

Source 1: <https://store.steampowered.com/app/200510/>

AIDEN AND TANK / THE COALITION CHORUS

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P053 / READ THE CATCH FIRST

XCOM 2

Edition considered: PC base game; not War of the Chosen expansion

Lead a resistance under alien occupation, developing soldiers whose ambushes, successes, and losses become the history of a mobile organization.

What you do. Inspect cover and movement boundaries, choose soldiers' actions, and manage the base, skills, and mission objectives across the resistance campaign.

Mixed controls | Usually waits for choices | Single-player; a friend can share the decisions

Main catch. Turn limits create urgency; camera operations, held-Control waypoint paths, and permanent casualties add demands in the base game.

Why it might click. The sequel turns Earth's defenders into an insurgent force, building a mobile organization and conducting tactical missions under alien occupation. Ambushes, soldier development and the changing campaign give each squad's successes and losses a continuing personal history.

The full catch. Turn limits create strategic urgency without requiring a fast mouse click. The manual also describes many action controls, camera operations and a held Control-key gesture for waypoint paths. Base management, skill trees and permanent casualties add weight. This is the base game; expansion options for changing timers are not assumed.

Try this first. Leave the tutorial enabled and inspect one soldier's movement boundary and cover information. Read a turn-limited objective literally when it appears, then decide whether pressure measured in decisions is acceptable even when the decision itself can be considered.

Aiden's complete scene and the source notes follow on the next page.

AIDEN AND TANK / THE COALITION CHORUS

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P053 / THE COMIC SCENE AND SOURCES

XCOM 2

AIDEN AT THE SUMMIT / The Resistance Has Occupied the Photo Booth

XCOM 2's resistance put ideas into Porsche's head. She and Mercedes took over the sponsor photo booth after its operator insisted every photograph needed his bottle in the foreground.

"He bought the backdrop," I said. "He didn't buy my face," Mercedes said.

Velvet joined them with the surviving inflatable alien. Remy supplied a crown. The booth rapidly produced a series of excellent pictures in which the sponsor's product appeared nowhere except accidentally beneath a chair.

I approached as mediator. Porsche handed me a plain backdrop cloth and asked me to hold one corner. The resistance had conscripted its supposedly neutral observer.

Kit adjusted the light. Rae took Nia's picture, then let Nia take hers. Neither called it anything more significant than a photograph, which was why I was absolutely forbidden to provide commentary.

The sponsor accepted the alternate setup after Velvet offered a separately priced product shot. Nigga, the occupation ended through commercial negotiation, while I remained holding the cloth because everyone liked the angle.

Aiden's verdict. The insurgent campaign has strong squad appeal, but turn limits and other demands preserve its detour warning. Our photo-booth resistance won a plain backdrop and a voluntary advertising rate.

Evidence desk / checked 20 September 2026

Publisher supports base-game premise; official port manual documents turn-based actions, turn timers, casualties and held Control for waypoint movement. Waits concerns tactical decisions, not absence of turn pressure. No War of the Chosen options transferred.

Source 1: <https://store.steampowered.com/app/268500/>

Source 2: <https://www.feralinteractive.com/en/manuals/xcom2/latest/steam/>

AIDEN AND TANK / THE COALITION CHORUS

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P054 / READ THE CATCH FIRST

Invisible, Inc.

Edition considered: PC base game

Plan corporate infiltrations where different agents and equipment make one well-chosen action open an unexpected path through security toward a valuable escape.

What you do. Inspect guards and sight lines, use agent abilities or hacking resources, and plan an extraction while choosing actions across successive turns.

Mouse / pointer | Usually waits for choices | Single-player; a friend can share the decisions

Main catch. The alarm rises each turn, so thinking time does not remove pressure; abilities and extraction plans require substantial tracking.

Why it might click. Corporate espionage becomes a tactical puzzle about agents, security systems and getting out with something valuable. Different operatives and equipment combinations let a plan feel clever when a small, well-chosen action opens an unexpected route through trouble.

The full catch. The designer describes an alarm that rises at the end of each turn. Thinking time is available, but escalating consequences can still feel urgent. Agent abilities, hacking resources, sight lines and extraction plans create heavy demands. Custom modes exist, yet a specific no-pressure configuration has not been established here.

Try this first. Try the introductory mission and inspect a guard's attention and one available agent action. Watch what changes when the turn ends, then judge the alarm's emotional effect rather than deciding solely from the absence of a seconds countdown.

Aiden's complete scene and the source notes follow on the next page.

AIDEN AND TANK / THE COALITION CHORUS

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P054 / THE COMIC SCENE AND SOURCES

Invisible, Inc.

AIDEN AT THE SUMMIT / The Corporate Spy Wants the Dessert Password

Invisible, Inc.'s corporate espionage made me suspicious of a locked catering cart. Rosa told me it contained dessert and would open when dessert was supposed to open.

Tank studied the latch. "Any agents available?" Rae pointed at the schedule. "Your extraction window's in twenty minutes."

I offered to negotiate early access for senior leadership. Shawna asked whether leadership intended to eat dinner first. I said this was reconnaissance. She removed the dessert fork from my hand with considerable expertise.

Nia and Kit were discussing the actual security deposit. Kit wanted the hotel to acknowledge the condition of its lamps before anyone moved them. Nia approved the idea and asked Porsche to photograph the equipment.

While we handled useful corporate intelligence, Tank asked Rosa directly whether there were extra strawberries in the kitchen. There were. She brought him a bowl because it didn't disturb service.

Nigga completed the mission by knowing a person's name and asking a normal question. I was still explaining my stealth plan to a woman married to it.

Aiden's verdict. The espionage planning can feel clever, while rising alarms still create pressure. Our dessert operation succeeded through a polite request, leaving my elaborate infiltration plan without an employment opportunity.

Evidence desk / checked 20 September 2026

Publisher supports stealth systems/custom modes; first-person designer article explains alarm advancement per turn. No particular alarm-removal setting or full input accommodation is inferred.

Source 1: <https://store.steampowered.com/app/243970/>

Source 2: <https://www.gamedeveloper.com/design/game-design-deep-dive-alarm-systems-in-klei-s-i-invisible-inc-i->

AIDEN AND TANK / THE COALITION CHORUS

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P055 / READ THE CATCH FIRST

Shadowrun Returns

Edition considered: PC original release

Follow a murder investigation through Seattle's mix of magic, cybernetics, and corporate power, with a team whose different abilities support the job.

What you do. Read conversations, choose a starting archetype, and direct team actions in tactical battles while managing attributes, equipment, spells, and other abilities.

Mouse / pointer | Usually waits for choices | Single-player; a friend can share the decisions

Main catch. Reading and character systems are substantial; turn-based fights do not certify every mission demand or held gesture on the full path.

Why it might click. A murder investigation moves through a Seattle where cybernetics, magic and corporate power collide. The story offers an adult genre mixture, while turn-based team combat lets different kinds of characters contribute practical abilities to the same job.

The full catch. Character creation, attributes, equipment, spells and tactical positioning are substantial systems. The game also relies on considerable reading, so a mystery-led premise does not make it a simple detective interface. Turn-based fights allow consideration, but the complete mission path and every held gesture have not been independently tested.

Try this first. Pick one clear starting archetype and follow the first conversation before studying every possible build. In the first instructed battle, learn one basic action and one support option rather than trying to master magic, drones and hacking together.

Aiden's complete scene and the source notes follow on the next page.

AIDEN AND TANK / THE COALITION CHORUS

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P055 / THE COMIC SCENE AND SOURCES

Shadowrun Returns

AIDEN AT THE SUMMIT / The Mage Has Read the Catering Contract

Shadowrun Returns mixed magic and corporate trouble. I suggested our financial committee needed a mage. Nia asked whether a mage could make my personal purchases stop appearing under SHARED EXPENSES.

“That's advanced magic,” Tank said. “Nigga's been practicing for years.”

Rae found the charge for monogrammed tool rolls. I had bought them to honor her table repair. She stared at the initials. They were mine.

“It's a summit gift.” “Then why does it say AIDEN?” “Brand continuity.”

Velvet took one look and offered to use a roll for makeup brushes if I stopped calling it a diplomatic gesture. Remy wanted another for cables. Actual people found useful purposes while the corporation's founder struggled with its reputation.

Shawna drew a line through SHARED and wrote PERSONAL beneath the charge. Nia approved the classification without billing us for sorcery. Rae kept the plain tool roll she'd brought from home, tightened one final screw, and left my branding on the table where it belonged.

Aiden's verdict. The murder mystery's magic-and-technology mixture may reward learning its tactical systems. Our corporate enchantment broke when Shawna changed one expense label and nobody mistook my initials for generosity.

Evidence desk / checked 20 September 2026

Publisher describes Seattle murder investigation, classless development and single-player turn-based tactical RPG. Waits refers to combat decisions; no complete no-hold or low-complexity certification.

Source 1: <https://store.steampowered.com/app/234650/>

AIDEN AND TANK / THE COALITION CHORUS

Niggas, games up.

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P056 / READ THE CATCH FIRST

Shadowrun: Dragonfall - Director's Cut

Edition considered: PC Director's Cut

Meet a Berlin crew with distinct histories and difficult loyalties, where relationships offer a substantial reward for learning Shadowrun's tactical systems.

What you do. Talk with the team, follow the first job, and choose tactical actions using character roles, equipment, and abilities across the campaign.

Mouse / pointer | Usually waits for choices | Single-player; a friend can share the decisions

Main catch. This remains a reading-heavy tactical RPG; redesigned menus do not establish simplicity or settle every late mission's input demands.

Why it might click. Dragonfall brings Shadowrun's magic-and-technology world to Berlin and centers a crew with distinct personalities and histories. The Director's Cut expands the campaign and team material, making relationships and difficult loyalties a substantial reward for learning its tactical systems.

The full catch. This remains a reading-heavy tactical RPG with character builds, equipment and team abilities. Its redesigned interface is not evidence that menus are few or self-explanatory. The standalone Director's Cut differs from the earlier expansion; complete timing, held gestures and late mission demands have not been verified here.

Try this first. Meet the initial team and try a small portion of its first job, focusing on one character's role. Decide whether the conversations make you want to know these people before planning an optimized build or committing to every side mission.

Aiden's complete scene and the source notes follow on the next page.

AIDEN AND TANK / THE COALITION CHORUS

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P056 / THE COMIC SCENE AND SOURCES

Shadowrun: Dragonfall - Director's Cut

AIDEN AT THE SUMMIT / The Crew Has Conditions for Taking My Job

Dragonfall's crew had histories and loyalties. I recruited our own crew for a dangerous mission: persuade the hotel to refund the duplicate chair delivery. Everybody wanted to know the terms. Rae wanted me present so I couldn't summarize the conversation afterward. Nia wanted a time limit on how long she'd spend helping. Kit wanted the promised lamp left untouched during the expedition. Tank wanted food. Velvet wanted us back before her rehearsal. Remy wanted to perform his fanfare when we succeeded. We had not yet approached the manager and already possessed six competing victory conditions.

Shawna assembled the relevant receipts. She handed them to me, then made me read the first sentence of my own cancellation request aloud. It contained an apology and no mention of destiny.

The manager refunded the unopened chairs minus the stated fee. Rae accepted the result. Nia reclaimed her evening. Remy played two tasteful seconds before remembering his promise to be ridiculous and adding three gloriously unnecessary more.

Nigga, the crew had earned its ending. I had earned a smaller bill.

Aiden's verdict. The developed crew gives this campaign a strong personal draw, while its tactical and reading load remains. Our refund mission succeeded because every participant knew exactly what they wanted from it.

Evidence desk / checked 20 September 2026

Inspected exact Director's Cut page confirms standalone identity, Berlin, expanded missions/team material and revised combat/interface. No all-path timing/hold guarantee; mature themes include explicit violence and difficult backstories.

Source 1: <https://store.steampowered.com/app/300550/>

AIDEN AND TANK / THE COALITION CHORUS

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P057 / A MORE DEMANDING DETOUR

Shadowrun: Hong Kong - Extended Edition

Edition considered: PC Extended Edition

Explore a dense Hong Kong urban-fantasy setting with a developed crew and corporate intrigue, plus an additional campaign in the Extended Edition.

What you do. Read crew conversations, manage characters and inventory, and alternate tactical team encounters with the game's separate Matrix interactions during the campaign.

Mixed controls | Some real-time demands | Single-player; a friend can share the decisions

Main catch. Matrix stealth and timed code or symbol elements prevent assuming the whole game waits; a comfortable complete route is unverified.

Why it might click. The third standalone Shadowrun adventure offers a dense urban fantasy setting, a developed crew and corporate intrigue in Hong Kong. Its Extended Edition includes the later bonus campaign, giving players who enjoy the characters more story beyond the original ending.

The full catch. Do not treat the whole game as unhurried because combat takes turns. Its Matrix has stealth and timed code/symbol-matching elements reported in gameplay documentation. A comfortable way through all required instances has not been verified. Text, character builds and inventory management are also heavy; this is a deliberate story-focused detour.

Try this first. Assess an early crew conversation and the character interface, then investigate the Matrix requirements before committing to the campaign. If someone offers help, agree which operations they would handle instead of quietly assuming every later obstacle will disappear.

Aiden's complete scene and the source notes follow on the next page.

AIDEN AND TANK / THE COALITION CHORUS

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P057 / THE COMIC SCENE AND SOURCES

Shadowrun: Hong Kong - Extended Edition

AIDEN AT THE SUMMIT / The Matrix Password Is Under the Ice Bucket

Shadowrun's Hong Kong crew faced a dense world of intrigue. Our immediate intrigue concerned the sponsor's tablet, which contained the itemized charges and refused to open without a code.

I announced we would need a hacker. Mika lifted the ice bucket. The code was on a card beneath it. "We need a dry card."

Nia read the charges while Rae held a napkin against the wet corner. Velvet found a proposed fee for using her stage name in a sponsor slideshow. She asked who had decided that was a benefit to her.

The sponsor called it promotional synergy. Remy made a sad little keyboard noise. Mercedes asked him to repeat it under the phrase, which improved the presentation enormously.

We removed the unapproved slide. Velvet offered a separate rate if the sponsor wanted her involvement. He declined, and everybody survived the absence of synergy.

I tried locking the tablet dramatically at the end. It played a cheerful confirmation sound. Nigga, our cyberpunk operation concluded like somebody successfully setting a kitchen timer.

Aiden's verdict. The crew and urban-fantasy setting are appealing, but Matrix timing elements keep the no-rush limitation real. Our smaller intrusion required a napkin and locating the code somebody had already supplied.

Evidence desk / checked 20 September 2026

Exact Extended Edition publisher page confirms revised Matrix and bonus campaign. Community gameplay documentation describes timed Matrix minigames; full-path alternatives are unverified, so no untimed completion is promised.

Source 1: <https://store.steampowered.com/app/346940/>

Source 2: <https://shadowrun-series.fandom.com/wiki/Matrix>

AIDEN AND TANK / THE COALITION CHORUS

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P058 / A PLACE TO START

Wildermyth

Edition considered: PC base game

Watch ordinary heroes acquire relationships, transformations, and lasting histories, creating a tactical adventure partly discovered through the consequences of your choices.

What you do. Meet the heroes, choose event responses, and direct battle actions while developing abilities and relationships; shared play can divide hero control.

Mixed controls | Usually waits for choices | Native co-op in this edition

Main catch. Evolving characters and tactics require attention; injury and aging matter, and co-op still needs agreement about controls and decisions.

Why it might click. A band of initially ordinary heroes develops through tactical adventures, personal events and relationships. Characters can transform and carry their histories forward, giving the player a story that feels partly discovered through consequences rather than entirely delivered by a fixed cast.

The full catch. Tactical positioning, abilities, event choices and evolving characters all require attention. Injury, sacrifice and aging are part of the story. Native cooperative play can divide hero control, but setup and shared decisions still need agreement; it is not automatic simplification. Every input and late sequence has not been audited.

Try this first. Begin an introductory campaign and meet the first heroes before judging their long-term builds. Try one event choice and one battle action. If sharing play, agree who controls which hero and whether advice is invited.

Aiden's complete scene and the source notes follow on the next page.

AIDEN AND TANK / THE COALITION CHORUS

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Niggas, sign here.

Niggas, stay petty.

Niggas, we're good.

P058 / THE COMIC SCENE AND SOURCES

Wildermyth

AIDEN AT THE SUMMIT / The Hero Has Acquired an Unflattering Nickname

Wildermyth's ordinary people could develop extraordinary histories. Remy asked whether the summit would remember him as King Receipts the Glorious. Velvet said it depended on how many fanfares he attempted before dinner.

Tank nominated me as Aiden the Charged. June preferred Aiden of the Many Deposits. Dez said my legend needed fewer syllables and more shame.

I tried naming my own heroic transformation: the Unifier. Rae looked at the budget balloons. "The Inflator." Nia laughed, then apologized without sounding sorry.

Kit wanted a better title too. She proposed Keeper of the Entrance Light. Mercedes granted it immediately, along with responsibility for remembering where she'd put her glasses. The hero checked her head before searching anywhere else.

Shawna leaned into me. "I like the man before his titles." I whispered something suitably promising about his other talents. She smiled and reminded him of the evening's private appointment.

My legend improved. No proclamation followed. The Unifier had discovered that a quiet sentence could outperform a rented banner when addressed to the correct woman.

Aiden's verdict. The evolving heroes and relationships can make this tactical story feel personal, with consequences and coordination still important. Our party has generated several legends, most of them less expensive than mine.

Evidence desk / checked 20 September 2026

Publisher supports evolving heroes, tactical battles, difficulty choices and cooperative campaign play with separately controlled heroes. Memory rating is editorial; co-op does not guarantee reduced burden or complete input comfort.

Source 1: <https://store.steampowered.com/app/763890/>

AIDEN AND TANK / THE COALITION CHORUS

Niggas, games up.

Niggas, pens out.

Niggas, chairs in.

Niggas, snacks here.

Niggas, receipts ready.

Niggas, lights on.

Niggas, mic check.

Niggas, take turns.

Niggas, dance later.

Niggas, read first.

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P059 / A MORE DEMANDING DETOUR

Wartales

Edition considered: PC base game

Build a medieval company's survival story through contracts, camp life, skills, and equipment, with native co-op offering a way to share it.

What you do. Inspect party and camp menus, choose contracts, manage supplies and equipment, and use professions alongside tactical battles and world exploration.

Mixed controls | Some real-time demands | Native co-op in this edition

Main catch. Some professions use timed minigames; avoiding them throughout a chosen route is unverified, and party management is extensive.

Why it might click. Lead a band through a harsh medieval world, choosing contracts and gradually shaping its camp, skills and equipment. The appeal is the practical, emergent story of a company surviving together rather than fulfilling a single hero's destiny; native co-op can share that company.

The full catch. Food, money, gear, professions and tactical battles create extensive management. Some profession activities use timing-based minigames, so turn-based combat does not mean a completely untimed game. A whole-route way around those activities is unverified. Exploration and party maintenance add further demands; this is a marked detour.

Try this first. Inspect an opening party and camp menu before pursuing contracts. Check the specific profession interactions a chosen plan would need, and only then consider a short shared outing with clear agreement about who handles each operation.

Aiden's complete scene and the source notes follow on the next page.

AIDEN AND TANK / THE COALITION CHORUS

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P059 / THE COMIC SCENE AND SOURCES

Wartales

AIDEN AT THE SUMMIT / The Mercenary Company Has a Snack Clause

Wartales' working company made Rosa examine our catering agreement like a mercenary captain. She wanted clear hours, sufficient staff, and nobody treating the kitchen as a magical room that generated plates.

I said I respected the craft. She pointed at the overtime request. "Then respect it numerically."

Rae backed her, partly on principle and partly because the replacement crackers had transformed her opinion of the summit. Kit wanted the staff to have a break before her karaoke turn so they could enjoy themselves if they wished.

Nia drafted one clean payment line. Her handwriting looked like a decorative threat. Mika typed it while she read aloud, preserving the actual words and mercifully abandoning the penmanship.

Darnell approached with a vague proposal involving a yacht chef. Rosa asked for a name and a rate. He had neither. Tank escorted his nigga toward a plate before the proposal developed further.

We funded the staff hours. The company secured its contract, and I gained no heroic title beyond the name already printed on my card.

Aiden's verdict. The company's emergent journey has appeal, while timed professions and extensive management remain genuine catches. Our catering captain obtained clear terms, paid time, and freedom from Darnell's imaginary yacht kitchen.

Evidence desk / checked 20 September 2026

Publisher confirms open-world company management, turn-based combat and up-to-four-player co-op. Gamepressure's profession guide describes timing minigames. Their complete avoidability has not been established.

Source 1: <https://store.steampowered.com/app/1527950/>

Source 2: <https://www.gamepressure.com/newsroom/professions-in-wartales-explained-list-and-description/zd543a>

AIDEN AND TANK / THE COALITION CHORUS

Niggas, games up.

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P060 / READ THE CATCH FIRST

Battle Brothers

Edition considered: PC base game

Lead a mercenary company through a harsh, unscripted world where recruitment, contracts, equipment, and battlefield outcomes create a history you can recognize.

What you do. Inspect recruits and gear, read contracts, travel across the world, and direct turn-based battles while paying wages and managing injuries.

Mixed controls | Some real-time demands | Single-player; a friend can share the decisions

Main catch. World travel is real-time while battles use turns; pause behavior needs checking, and harsh consequences accompany extensive management.

Why it might click. A mercenary company develops its own history through recruits, contracts, equipment and battles in a changing world. The appeal is a tough, unscripted campaign where decisions leave marks and a modest success can feel earned because failure remains possible.

The full catch. The publisher explicitly separates real-time world travel from turn-based battles. Roster management, wages, equipment, injuries and risk assessment are substantial. Harsh consequences can produce pressure even when battle decisions wait. Pause behavior during travel and every held-input requirement need checking; this is not a low-management fantasy adventure.

Try this first. Inspect a starting company's people and equipment, then read one contract's terms before accepting anything. Test travel controls and pausing deliberately. If the administrative burden already dominates the fun, another entry deserves the evening instead.

Aiden's complete scene and the source notes follow on the next page.

AIDEN AND TANK / THE COALITION CHORUS

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P060 / THE COMIC SCENE AND SOURCES

Battle Brothers

AIDEN AT THE SUMMIT / The Brothers Demand a Contract Before the Toast

Battle Brothers' mercenary company attracted June. "Everybody signs before anybody carries anything," she said. Dez raised an eyebrow. "Look at the Blue Comet discovering contracts." June and Dez inspected their two-sided copies of the 1967 agreement. Both signatures were undeniable now. June insisted signatures only mattered if promises were kept. Dez inspected the alternating-song clause and suggested June had spent fifty-nine years negotiating with the fucking jukebox.

I offered a toast to old alliances. Velvet asked whether the current deposit had cleared. Nia checked the confirmation. It hadn't. The toast waited while I found the correct message on my phone. Rae and Kit compared the actual staffing numbers. Remy brought Velvet water because she had stopped talking and that worried him more than her talking ever did.

The confirmation arrived. Velvet relaxed, thanked him, and accepted the glass. June raised hers. Dez raised hers too, without conceding the jacket claim. Nigga, we had an alliance with conditions, which looked a lot like an ordinary agreement between people intending to remain friends after the evening cost money.

Aiden's verdict. The unscripted company history can be compelling, with harsh consequences and real-time travel carefully noted. Our alliance has postponed its toast until the payment confirmation becomes more than a hopeful promise.

Evidence desk / checked 20 September 2026

Publisher describes real-time travel, turn-based combat and mercenary contract/equipment management. Travel pause/hold details are not established here; strategic pressure is an editorial warning, not a seconds-timer claim.

Source 1: <https://store.steampowered.com/app/365360/>

AIDEN AND TANK / THE COALITION CHORUS

Niggas, games up.	Niggas, pens out.	Niggas, chairs in.	Niggas, snacks here.	Niggas, receipts ready.
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P061 / READ THE CATCH FIRST

BATTLETECH

Edition considered: PC base game

Command giant combat machines in a mercenary company where personalities, damage, and tactical outcomes continue to matter after the battle ends.

What you do. Inspect a machine's movement and weapons, make battlefield choices, and manage loadouts, repairs, contracts, and the company's equipment between engagements.

Mixed controls | Usually waits for choices | Single-player; a friend can share the decisions

Main catch. Technical menus and economic consequences are substantial; listed competitive multiplayer does not establish a cooperative story campaign.

Why it might click. Command enormous combat machines while managing the mercenary company behind them. The attraction is the connection between personalities, damaged equipment and tactical decisions: a battle's outcome follows the crew back to a traveling base rather than vanishing at a results screen.

The full catch. Weapon loadouts, heat, armor, positioning, repairs and contracts create substantial technical and menu demands. Battles take turns, yet long engagements and economic consequences can still feel taxing. The publisher lists competitive multiplayer and solo skirmishes; do not infer cooperative campaign play from sharing a screen or discussing tactics.

Try this first. Try the opening instruction or a solo skirmish and inspect one machine's movement and weapon choices. Before accepting a company-wide campaign, decide whether reading its equipment information is an enjoyable part of the experience or simply too much administration.

Aiden's complete scene and the source notes follow on the next page.

AIDEN AND TANK / THE COALITION CHORUS

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P061 / THE COMIC SCENE AND SOURCES

BATTLETECH

AIDEN AT THE SUMMIT / The Battle Machine Has a Dry-Cleaning Bill

BATTLETECH's enormous machines made my mechanical photo throne look almost restrained. I said so. Rae crouched beside its bent footrest and asked whether restraint included the repair charge. "It came like that." Shawna found the photograph of me standing on it. "It came considerably flatter." Mika loved the chair's ridiculous silhouette. They suggested using it motionless in a corner for photographs. The hotel technician disconnected the troublesome mechanism, leaving a perfectly decent seat inside an absurd shell.

Remy climbed in and looked magnificent until his crown caught the top edge. Velvet removed the crown, sat on the broad arm, and told the photographer to proceed. Two professionals salvaged the machine through superior positioning.

I asked for a solo picture. Tank sat in my lap before the camera flashed. "Crew portrait, nigga." The photograph contained two grown men, one enormous chair, and my expression discovering new dimensions of regret.

Rae taped a note over the control: OFF. Nia added the repair estimate to my personal column. Our mercenary machine had returned from battle with an itemized history.

Aiden's verdict. The connection between machines, crew, and company finances can be absorbing, with technical systems still substantial. Our damaged throne has retired into portrait work and left its commander holding the repair bill.

Evidence desk / checked 20 September 2026

Publisher supports turn-based mech combat, contracts, repairs, company management and solo skirmish/PvP modes. Complete held/camera interactions are not tested; no native co-op inferred.

Source 1: <https://store.steampowered.com/app/637090/>

AIDEN AND TANK / THE COALITION CHORUS

Niggas, games up.	Niggas, pens out.	Niggas, chairs in.	Niggas, snacks here.	Niggas, receipts ready.
Niggas, lights on.	Niggas, mic check.	Niggas, take turns.	Niggas, dance later.	Niggas, read first.
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P062 / READ THE CATCH FIRST

TRIANGLE STRATEGY

Edition considered: PC release

Explore political conflict where allies vote on major choices, making persuasion, scarce resources, and competing principles matter alongside tactical battles.

What you do. Read conversations, consider political choices, and direct units through positional battles while learning their abilities at a comfortable difficulty.

Mixed controls | Usually waits for choices | Single-player; a friend can share the decisions

Main catch. Untimed input and adjustable difficulty support pacing, but dialogue, political names, tactics, and menus still demand substantial attention.

Why it might click. Political conflict, scarce resources and competing principles shape a story in which allies can vote on major choices. Tactical battles and conversations both matter, making the central attraction the tension between personal conviction, persuasion and the needs of a group.

The full catch. The PC listing declares play without timed input, adjustable difficulty and saving at any time. Those features help pacing but do not shrink the dialogue, political names, unit abilities or positional tactics. Expect a heavy reading and menu load; the story's moral weight may itself feel demanding.

Try this first. Choose a comfortable difficulty and follow an early conversation before testing one explained battle action. Pay attention to whether the political questions interest you enough to learn the surrounding systems; no vote of the Bureau can supply that interest.

Aiden's complete scene and the source notes follow on the next page.

AIDEN AND TANK / THE COALITION CHORUS

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P062 / THE COMIC SCENE AND SOURCES

TRIANGLE STRATEGY

AIDEN AT THE SUMMIT / The Scales of Conviction Prefer Actual Dinner

TRIANGLE STRATEGY's voting allies made me propose a formal ballot on the summit menu. Rosa reminded me that the food was already prepared. I said the vote would affirm collective conviction. "Nigga, affirm it with a plate."

Kit wanted a vegetarian option kept clearly marked. Rae wanted the olives replenished. Remy wanted time to eat before his costume change. These requests required three practical adjustments, not an election between hungry people.

Nia suggested saving votes for genuinely unresolved choices. June immediately nominated the Blue Comet song. Dez vetoed a second play. June accused her of obstructing reconciliation through rhythm.

Mercedes offered to play a short instrumental echo during the break, which June accepted because she liked the arrangement and Dez accepted because nobody had to stand through the whole song again.

I announced consensus. Velvet corrected me: we had dinner requests and a musical compromise. Shawna put a plate in my hand before I could convert either into a constitutional doctrine. The scales of conviction tipped toward something hot and edible.

Aiden's verdict. The political choices and voting allies give the tactical story a distinctive appeal, with heavy names and systems retained. Our dinner negotiation required three adjustments and considerably fewer speeches than I proposed.

Evidence desk / checked 20 September 2026

Publisher supports conviction/voting and tactical systems; current PC metadata declares no timed input, adjustable difficulty and Save Anytime. These are declarations, not independent full-path control validation.

Source 1: <https://store.steampowered.com/app/1850510/>

AIDEN AND TANK / THE COALITION CHORUS

Niggas, games up.	Niggas, pens out.	Niggas, chairs in.	Niggas, snacks here.	Niggas, receipts ready.
Niggas, lights on.	Niggas, mic check.	Niggas, take turns.	Niggas, dance later.	Niggas, read first.
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P063 / READ THE CATCH FIRST

Tactics Ogre: Reborn

Edition considered: PC Reborn edition

Follow Denam through factional conflict, where branching decisions connect personal loyalties with public consequences in a sustained tactical political fantasy.

What you do. Read the political situation, direct units through battle turns, and manage a roster's equipment, classes, and abilities as choices branch.

Mixed controls | Usually waits for choices | Single-player; a friend can share the decisions

Main catch. Reborn declares untimed input, but rosters and political names require learning; selection and camera comfort still need testing.

Why it might click. Denam's decisions unfold amid factional conflict in a kingdom shaped by past rule and renewed war. Branching story choices and tactical battles make the appeal a sustained political fantasy in which personal loyalties and public consequences rarely stay neatly separate.

The full catch. The current Reborn PC listing declares no timed input, mouse-only and keyboard-only options, and saving at any time. Even so, a large roster, equipment, classes, battle rules and political names demand substantial learning. Reborn's revised systems differ from earlier releases; comfortable selection and camera use still need testing.

Try this first. Read the opening situation and try one unit's basic turn without planning an entire army. Keep a small character note if useful, then decide whether the political intrigue makes the menus feel worthwhile rather than automatically accepting them as a toll.

Aiden's complete scene and the source notes follow on the next page.

AIDEN AND TANK / THE COALITION CHORUS

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P063 / THE COMIC SCENE AND SOURCES

Tactics Ogre: Reborn

AIDEN AT THE SUMMIT / The Reborn Agreement Has the Same Old Jacket

Tactics Ogre's branching loyalties made June consider possible futures for the jacket claim. One future involved Dez apologizing. Another involved Dez returning it. A third involved June retaining excellent material for conversation.

Dez favored the third. "You've had fifty-nine years of entertainment." "And you had the fucking jacket."

Nia offered to separate sentimental value from replacement value. June surprised her by declining a price. She wanted Dez to admit the cardigan had never been equivalent. Dez looked at the old photograph for a long moment.

"It wasn't equivalent," she said. "It was warmer." June swatted her arm with the paper, laughing despite herself. The branch narrowed but did not close.

Rae wanted to see the original jacket restored to its first shape. Dez said she'd saved an alteration pattern somewhere. Kit asked whether June would model it. June immediately discussed lighting. I offered a commemorative runway. Shawna said one jacket did not require a new venue. Nigga, the future kept branching directly toward my credit card and being pruned by my wife.

Aiden's verdict. The branching political fantasy can reward sustained interest, with rosters and selection demands still present. Our jacket dispute has advanced to one partial admission and the possibility of excellent tailoring.

Evidence desk / checked 20 September 2026

Exact Reborn listing supports branching story, revised tactical systems and developer-declared no timed input/Mouse Only/Keyboard Only/Save Anytime. Complexity assessment is editorial, not a clinical rating.

Source 1: <https://store.steampowered.com/app/1451090/>

AIDEN AND TANK / THE COALITION CHORUS

Niggas, games up.	Niggas, pens out.	Niggas, chairs in.	Niggas, snacks here.	Niggas, receipts ready.
Niggas, lights on.	Niggas, mic check.	Niggas, take turns.	Niggas, dance later.	Niggas, read first.
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P064 / READ THE CATCH FIRST

FINAL FANTASY TACTICS - The Ivalice Chronicles

Edition considered: PC Enhanced version proposed for later assessment

Follow Ramza and Delita through Ivalice's struggle over class, power, and loyalty, with fully voiced dialogue in this edition's Enhanced version.

What you do. Choose Enhanced and Squire, then move characters and select battle actions while gradually learning jobs, equipment, and positioning during the story.

Mixed controls | Usually waits for choices | Single-player; a friend can share the decisions

Main catch. Squire lowers a barrier without removing tactical systems; Classic differs, and held-input or camera comfort has not been verified.

Why it might click. Ramza and Delita are drawn through a struggle over power, class and competing loyalties in Ivalice. This edition's Enhanced version adds fully voiced dialogue and refinements, offering a specific modern route into a substantial tactical story rather than an unspecified nostalgic recommendation.

The full catch. Use Enhanced with Squire difficulty for the proposed trial. That lowers a barrier but does not remove job systems, equipment, positioning or a large cast of names. The Classic version has different features. Complete held-input and camera comfort remain unverified, and a gentler setting does not make every battle simple.

Try this first. Select Enhanced and Squire, then follow the opening explanation through one character's movement and action. Read only the abilities immediately available before considering future job combinations; the first question is whether this turn feels understandable and interesting.

Aiden's complete scene and the source notes follow on the next page.

AIDEN AND TANK / THE COALITION CHORUS

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P064 / THE COMIC SCENE AND SOURCES

FINAL FANTASY TACTICS - The Ivalice Chronicles

AIDEN AT THE SUMMIT / The Noble Class Has Lost Its Drink Tokens

The Ivalice story's class conflict made Rae examine the gold and silver drink tokens I'd ordered. I explained that gold represented summit leadership. She asked who had appointed it.

I looked at my own handful of gold. Nigga, evidence can be very loud without making a sound.

Nia wanted the distinction removed. Kit wanted her silver token accepted at the same bar as everyone else's. Velvet pointed out that performers had been assigned none because somebody assumed they wouldn't want refreshments while working.

Rosa called the bar manager over. We replaced both colors with one clear arrangement and made sure the staff knew it. The man looked relieved to lose a rule nobody had explained consistently.

Remy took the unused gold tokens for his costume. They made an excellent little ceremonial chain.

Velvet said it suited him. He blushed so openly that the entire room briefly became kinder.

I asked whether I could keep one token as founder. Shawna put it in my pocket. "Souvenir, baby. Not a political system." The noble class retired beside my room key.

Aiden's verdict. The Enhanced edition offers a particular route into this substantial political story, with tactical and control demands retained. Our class distinction has become a drag-king necklace and one useless souvenir.

Evidence desk / checked 20 September 2026

Square Enix's current official page confirms exact title, Enhanced/Classic distinction, voiced Enhanced dialogue and Squire difficulty. Job/ability complexity is documented; complete no-hold/camera comfort is not.

Source 1: <https://final-fantasy-tactics-the-ivalice-chronicles.square-enix-games.com/en-us>

AIDEN AND TANK / THE COALITION CHORUS

Niggas, games up.

Niggas, pens out.

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P065 / READ THE CATCH FIRST

Disgaea 5 Complete

Edition considered: PC Complete edition

Enjoy an extravagant demonic rebellion where huge numbers and unusual combinations make increasingly elaborate systems part of the comedy and attraction.

What you do. Try the opening move-and-act battle loop, then gradually explore jobs, items, special mechanics, and customization if those systems become enjoyable.

Mixed controls | Usually waits for choices | Single-player; a friend can share the decisions

Main catch. The Complete edition adds extensive material and deep systems; turn-based decisions do not make its menu or memory burden light.

Why it might click. Disgaea 5 turns tactical role-playing into an extravagant comic machine of demons, rebellion, huge numbers and unusual combinations. Its appeal is enjoying systems that become increasingly ridiculous, with a cast and world equally happy to push beyond ordinary fantasy restraint.

The full catch. The Complete edition contains extensive added material and many deep systems: jobs, items, special battle mechanics and customization. That is a major menu and memory burden, not a promise of more effortless entertainment. Turn-based decisions help pacing, but the publisher's abundance is exactly the catch for someone wanting few systems.

Try this first. Try only the opening explanation and a basic battle action. Leave bonus scenarios and long-term optimization alone until the fundamental move-and-act loop feels enjoyable; there is no requirement to consume everything included in the word Complete.

Aiden's complete scene and the source notes follow on the next page.

AIDEN AND TANK / THE COALITION CHORUS

Niggas, games up.

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P065 / THE COMIC SCENE AND SOURCES

Disgaea 5 Complete

AIDEN AT THE SUMMIT / The Damage Number Is My Bar Estimate

Disgaea 5's glorious numerical excess made Remy read my event estimate like a battle result. He started with the chandelier line and increased his dramatic voice for every extra zero.

Velvet accompanied him with an increasingly horrified piano chord. Mercedes let her because the timing was excellent.

I said big numbers could represent big ambition. Rae found three separate charges for gold ribbon. "This nigga has dealt critical damage to stationery." Kit corrected her that ribbon wasn't stationery, then admitted the distinction did not improve my defense.

Mika wanted one roll retained for the ceremony. They knew exactly where it would go. The other two could still be returned, which made their specific extravagance considerably more persuasive than my general one.

Nia marked the refund. Tank asked whether we could convert the savings into better dessert. Rosa said dessert was already good and he could stop campaigning before tasting it.

The damage report ended. Remy bowed. I survived with fewer ribbons and a numerical reputation that nobody intended to let me forget before breakfast.

Aiden's verdict. The exaggerated tactical systems can be a pleasure for someone who enjoys their depth, with dense menus understood. Our largest damage number belongs to a host repeatedly defeated by decorative ribbon.

Evidence desk / checked 20 September 2026

Exact Complete listing documents included scenarios, jobs, customization and multiple strategic systems. Waits is tactical decision pacing; no full-path no-hold or low-menu claim is made.

Source 1: <https://store.steampowered.com/app/803600/>

AIDEN AND TANK / THE COALITION CHORUS

Niggas, games up.

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P066 / READ THE CATCH FIRST

Disgaea 7: Vows of the Virtueless

Edition considered: PC base game

Follow a reluctant fighter and enthusiastic client through demonic comic excess, where oversized transformations turn tactical possibilities into increasingly unreasonable spectacle.

What you do. Learn movement and attacks, select targets through PC menus, and explore character classes, items, and special battle mechanics as interest grows.

Mixed controls | Usually waits for choices | Single-player; a friend can share the decisions

Main catch. Systems remain dense, and auto-battle unlocks only after completing each stage; it is not a verified first-pass story bypass.

Why it might click. A reluctant fighter and an enthusiastic client anchor a demonic tactical adventure with exaggerated powers and comic excess. New systems such as oversized combat transformations fit a series whose appeal includes seeing a seemingly sensible strategy become gloriously unreasonable.

The full catch. The PC publisher specifically supports keyboard/mouse menu and target selection, but the many classes, items and mechanics remain dense. Auto-battle unlocks after successfully completing each stage; it is not a verified first-pass story bypass. Turn-based structure does not settle every held-input requirement or make the management light.

Try this first. Learn the first battle's ordinary movement and attack before opening every customization possibility. Test whether the PC menu and target controls feel clear, and judge the cast's humor separately from the attraction of increasingly elaborate numerical combinations.

Aiden's complete scene and the source notes follow on the next page.

AIDEN AND TANK / THE COALITION CHORUS

Niggas, games up.

Niggas, pens out.

Niggas, chairs in.

Niggas, snacks here.

Niggas, receipts ready.

Niggas, lights on.

Niggas, mic check.

Niggas, take turns.

Niggas, dance later.

Niggas, read first.

Niggas, pick freely.

Niggas, no rush.

Niggas, sign here.

Niggas, stay petty.

Niggas, we're good.

P066 / THE COMIC SCENE AND SOURCES

Disgaea 7: Vows of the Virtueless

AIDEN AT THE SUMMIT / The Giant Transformation Doesn't Fit Through the Door

Disgaea 7's oversized transformations encouraged Mika to show us a concept for Velvet's entrance: a towering silhouette projected behind her, filling the wall from floor to ceiling.

Velvet loved it. So did Kit, which she admitted only after checking how it affected the next light cue. I tried claiming the idea as an extension of my own monument strategy.

"Nigga, this one's her size on purpose," Tank said.

The first test made Velvet's headpiece appear to grow through the ceiling. Remy stood beneath it and announced himself a humble subject. She reached down theatrically while he offered the revised payment envelope.

Rae and Nia laughed together. I admired the effect, then asked what it cost. Mika pointed at the projector already in the room. For once a giant idea didn't require a giant additional invoice.

Shawna kissed my cheek when I stopped searching for a way to make it cost more. Velvet rehearsed the entrance twice, each enormous shadow perfectly timed by people who actually knew their jobs.

Aiden's verdict. The comic tactical excess has its own appeal, while dense systems and first-pass limits remain important. Our giant transformation succeeded because the projector was already paid for and Velvet deserved the wall.

Evidence desk / checked 20 September 2026

Base PC listing supports Fuji/Pirilika, Jumbification, keyboard/mouse menu controls and auto-battle unlocked by completed stages. No complete-edition extras, unconditional autoplay or hold-free guarantee is inferred.

Source 1: <https://store.steampowered.com/app/2250600/>

AIDEN AND TANK / THE COALITION CHORUS

Niggas, games up.

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P067 / READ THE CATCH FIRST

Chained Echoes

Edition considered: PC release

Travel with an ensemble across a war-torn world of dragons and machines, with political trouble and personal stories sustaining the journey.

What you do. Move through the world, read the cast's story, and select turn-based battle actions while learning skills and managing equipment along the way.

Direction + buttons | Some real-time demands | Single-player; a friend can share the decisions

Main catch. The publisher describes complex skills and equipment; directional movement may require holds, and every potential timing question is not settled.

Why it might click. An ensemble crosses a war-torn continent in a fantasy world that mixes dragons and machines with a deliberate older-RPG visual style. The appeal is a long journey through varied places, with character stories and political trouble giving the travels a continuing purpose.

The full catch. The publisher explicitly describes a complex skill and equipment system. Turn-based battles permit choosing actions, while exploration still requires directional movement and may involve sustained inputs. Visible enemies replace random encounters, but that does not eliminate combat, navigation demands or every potential timing question across the whole story.

Try this first. Follow the opening until you can test one movement segment and one explained battle choice. Read the currently useful skill information, then decide whether the cast and world make further systems learning attractive rather than assuming retro-looking graphics mean retro-sized complexity.

Aiden's complete scene and the source notes follow on the next page.

AIDEN AND TANK / THE COALITION CHORUS

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P067 / THE COMIC SCENE AND SOURCES

Chained Echoes

AIDEN AT THE SUMMIT / The Dragon Has a Mechanical Expense Account

Chained Echoes' mixture of dragons and machines reminded me that I'd ordered a mechanical dragon centerpiece for the financial table. I had prudently forgotten to mention this during the fountain discussion.

The delivery man did the mentioning. Rae folded her arms. Nia stopped writing. Tank whispered, "Nigga's got downloadable debt."

The dragon was small, handsome, and completely unnecessary. Mika loved it instantly. Their miniature hotel collection apparently had room for a serious zoning problem. They offered to borrow it for the floor-plan display if it could remain unplugged.

I wanted to demonstrate the moving wings. Shawna asked whether that would make it nonreturnable. The delivery man nodded. My hand withdrew from the switch with the dignity of a man encountering a poisonous snake.

We photographed it for Mika, kept the packaging intact, and sent it back. They sighed sincerely, then placed their smallest model hotel beside the empty space.

Velvet watched the departure. "Good dragon. Came, threatened the treasury, left." Remy supplied one heroic chord. I accepted survival without merchandise.

Aiden's verdict. The ensemble journey's mixture of fantasy and machinery may be attractive, with movement and system questions retained. Our mechanical dragon threatened the treasury before departing safely inside its original packaging.

Evidence desk / checked 20 September 2026

Publisher supports story-driven ensemble journey, visible enemies, turn-based battles and complex equipment/skills. Held movement and complete path comfort are unverified; no all-game no-timer claim.

Source 1: <https://store.steampowered.com/app/1229240/>

AIDEN AND TANK / THE COALITION CHORUS

Niggas, games up.

Niggas, pens out.

Niggas, chairs in.

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P068 / A MORE DEMANDING DETOUR

Sea of Stars

Edition considered: PC base game

Join companions in a colorful sun-and-moon fantasy adventure, with local cooperative story play available through the Dawn of Equinox update.

What you do. Move through the world, inspect difficulty and relic options, and choose battle actions that include timed hits during the companions' journey.

Mixed controls | Some real-time demands | Native co-op in this edition

Main catch. Timed hits are real, including in co-op; a complete route avoiding every timed or held action has not been established.

Why it might click. A colorful, classically inspired role-playing journey follows Solstice Warriors through a world of sun-and-moon magic. The combination of scenery, companions and adventure is the attraction; the Dawn of Equinox update also makes the story available in local cooperative play.

The full catch. Timed hits are a real combat mechanic, including in co-op. The developer documents difficulty presets and relic adjustments, but this research does not establish a complete path avoiding every timed or held action. Movement and traversal require separate checks. Treat it as a deliberate detour rather than assuming turn-based means entirely unrushed.

Try this first. Inspect the installed version's difficulty and relic explanations, then test movement and one early battle with no expectation of perfect timing. If the required operations already conflict with preferences, enjoy the premise and choose another route without a mastery assignment.

Aiden's complete scene and the source notes follow on the next page.

AIDEN AND TANK / THE COALITION CHORUS

Niggas, games up.

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P068 / THE COMIC SCENE AND SOURCES

Sea of Stars

AIDEN AT THE SUMMIT / The Sun and Moon Have Separate Lighting Invoices

Sea of Stars' sun-and-moon magic made Kit and Mika discuss alternating warm and cool light over the stage. I heard the word alternating and prepared to authorize another rental.

Kit stopped me. "We have both lights." "But do we have the vision?" "Aiden, we have switches."

Remy wanted his fanfare beneath the warm light. Velvet wanted the cool one for her first pose. Mercedes tried the transition while Nia and Rae watched from the side of the room, sharing the last respectable crackers.

June asked for a blue light during the Blue Comet song. Dez said the original club had one working bulb and June was improving history. June admitted the improvement looked excellent.

I volunteered to operate the cues. Three people declined with such synchronized politeness that I suspected rehearsal. Mika took the controls and made the room look like an actual evening instead of a showroom.

Shawna led me to a chair. "You can watch something beautiful without directing it." I looked at her. For once the nigga answered correctly.

Aiden's verdict. The colorful journey and cooperative option can invite interest, while real timed hits preserve the warning. Our sun-and-moon experiment works through existing lights and a host finally enjoying the view.

Evidence desk / checked 20 September 2026

Developer describes original story with Dawn of Equinox's up-to-three-player local co-op, timed hits and difficulty presets. This assesses that updated base adventure, not the OST or unverified Sunset Edition changes. Complete no-timed/hold path unknown.

Source 1: <https://sabotagestudio.com/press-release/sabotage-studio-announces-free-sea-of-stars-update-dawn-of-equinox-bringing-top-fan-requested-additions-to-pc-and-consoles-gains-november-release-date/>

AIDEN AND TANK / THE COALITION CHORUS

Niggas, games up.	Niggas, pens out.	Niggas, chairs in.	Niggas, snacks here.	Niggas, receipts ready.
Niggas, lights on.	Niggas, mic check.	Niggas, take turns.	Niggas, dance later.	Niggas, read first.
Niggas, pick freely.	Niggas, no rush.	Niggas, sign here.	Niggas, stay petty.	Niggas, we're good.

P069 / READ THE CATCH FIRST

OCTOPATH TRAVELER II

Edition considered: PC release

Choose among eight protagonists with distinct motives, then discover how their different beginnings and an expanding cast relate within one shared world.

What you do. Follow a chosen traveler's opening, select battle actions, and manage jobs, equipment, movement, and character abilities as the wider journey develops.

Direction + buttons | Some real-time demands | Single-player; a friend can share the decisions

Main catch. Untimed input is declared, but eight stories and battle systems add memory load; comfortable directional holds remain a separate question.

Why it might click. Eight protagonists bring separate motivations and talents to a shared world, with stories that can be approached through different beginnings. The attraction is choosing a person who catches your interest, then discovering how an expanding cast and their journeys relate.

The full catch. The PC listing declares play without timed input, but battles still use several interacting systems and the wider journey includes movement, jobs, equipment and distinct character abilities. Remembering eight stories can become substantial. Directional hold comfort remains a separate question even when battle selections wait.

Try this first. Choose one traveler because the premise appeals, read that opening, and learn one ordinary battle action. Keep the next step attached to that character before treating the whole ensemble as a single large list of unfinished obligations.

Aiden's complete scene and the source notes follow on the next page.

AIDEN AND TANK / THE COALITION CHORUS

Niggas, games up.

Niggas, pens out.

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Niggas, stay petty.

Niggas, we're good.

P069 / THE COMIC SCENE AND SOURCES

OCTOPATH TRAVELER II

AIDEN AT THE SUMMIT / Eight Protagonists Refuse to Share One Expense Code

OCTOPATH's eight different beginnings made me appreciate the summit's competing stories. I asked eight people to describe their immediate objective. The exercise became dangerous before the fourth answer.

Velvet wanted payment. Remy wanted his fanfare. Kit wanted karaoke. Rae wanted proper snacks. Nia wanted the financial meeting to end while there was still an evening left to enjoy.

Rosa wanted the kitchen schedule respected. Mercedes wanted a clean recording. Shawna wanted her husband to stop conducting surprise exercises when she had already told him her objective twice.

I counted myself as a ninth protagonist. Tank leaned over from his chair. "I'm ten, nigga. My story involves eating without an interview."

Mika wrote each cost beside the actual request. Some required money; others required me to stop occupying the microphone. The second category had an astonishingly favorable price.

Nia finished her glass and asked Rae about the bike outside. Their story moved forward without submitting another expense. I let it, partly from maturity and partly because my wife had confiscated the marker.

Aiden's verdict. The eight personal journeys offer different reasons to begin, with substantial memory and movement demands retained. Our ensemble's cheapest wish is for the host to stop interviewing people between bites.

Evidence desk / checked 20 September 2026

Exact PC listing supports eight travelers, Path Actions, jobs and Break/Boost; developer declares no timed input. Mixed label reflects active exploration alongside waiting battle decisions, not a contradicted timer claim. Hold comfort unverified.

Source 1: <https://store.steampowered.com/app/1971650/>

AIDEN AND TANK / THE COALITION CHORUS

Niggas, games up.

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Niggas, chairs in.

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P070 / READ THE CATCH FIRST

DRAGON QUEST XI S: Echoes of an Elusive Age - Definitive Edition

Edition considered: PC Definitive Edition

Join an accused hero and growing band of companions in a colorful identity-searching adventure, with both personal backstories and traditional turn-based battles.

What you do. Inspect presentation choices, move through the world, and choose party actions while managing equipment and abilities across a long companion-filled story.

Mixed controls | Some real-time demands | Single-player; a friend can share the decisions

Main catch. The 3D camera, directional holds, and optional minigames need checking; the 2D option is not an instant universal solution.

Why it might click. A young hero accused of being a threat gathers companions and searches for the truth of his identity. The appeal is a substantial, colorful adventure with personal backstories and a traditional turn-based battle structure; this edition also includes a two-dimensional presentation option.

The full catch. Party equipment, abilities, navigation and a long story create a meaningful memory load. The 3D presentation brings camera demands; trying 2D may change that burden but is not a universal solution or instant switch at every moment. Directional holds and optional minigame timing remain separate checks.

Try this first. Inspect the Definitive Edition's presentation choices and begin without extra Draconian challenge settings. Try ordinary movement and one early turn-based battle, judging both the immediate controls and whether the companions' tone makes a long adventure sound inviting.

Aiden's complete scene and the source notes follow on the next page.

AIDEN AND TANK / THE COALITION CHORUS

Niggas, games up.

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Niggas, we're good.

P070 / THE COMIC SCENE AND SOURCES

DRAGON QUEST XI S: Echoes of an Elusive Age - Definitive Edition

AIDEN AT THE SUMMIT / The Two-Dimensional Kingdom Has Better Parking

Dragon Quest's hero had a complicated identity. I had a complicated floor plan, which Mika translated into a small arrangement of model hotels, paper tables, and a single toy chandelier.

I loved it. I immediately asked whether a miniature statue of me could fit near the entrance. Rae moved the tiny table into that space instead.

"Now people can sign." "But where do I go?" Shawna tapped the chair beside her. "Try here, your majesty."

Kit found it easier to discuss the lighting when she could point at a small stage. Velvet moved her changing area away from the little paper bar. Remy placed his crown token beside the microphone and declared the kingdom stable.

Nia reminded us that the real room still needed checking later. The model wasn't a magic substitute for walking through the actual arrangement. Mika agreed and photographed the proposed version for the venue discussion.

I slipped a tiny gold token into the entrance afterward. Tank caught me. "Nigga, even your miniature needs supervision." He returned the table and ate a cracker with victorious calm.

Aiden's verdict. The traditional adventure and presentation options may appeal, with camera, holds, and minigames still requiring checks. Our miniature kingdom helps discussion while leaving the actual room for a later inspection.

Evidence desk / checked 20 September 2026

Inspected exact XI S Definitive page confirms 2D/3D modes, companions, turn-based combat and optional Draconian challenges. Mode-switch limits and full input/timing comfort are not fully verified; no original-XI assumptions.

Source 1: <https://store.steampowered.com/app/1295510/>

AIDEN AND TANK / THE COALITION CHORUS

Niggas, games up.

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Niggas, stay petty.

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P071 / A MORE DEMANDING DETOUR

Persona 5 Royal

Edition considered: PC Royal edition

Spend time with a stylish ensemble whose daily relationships connect to a supernatural struggle against abusive power, supported by striking music and presentation.

What you do. Read conversations, plan calendar choices and relationships, explore dungeons, and select combat actions while following the ensemble's long character story.

Mixed controls | Some real-time demands | Single-player; a friend can share the decisions

Main catch. Required later countdowns and timed traversal conflict with strict no-rush needs; menus, calendar planning, and camera handling add complexity.

Why it might click. A stylish ensemble of students balances daily relationships with a supernatural campaign against abusive power. Royal offers an extensive character story with striking music and presentation, making the desire to spend time with its cast entirely understandable even when its systems are demanding.

The full catch. This is a detour for a strict no-rush preference. Royal walkthroughs document a required later boss with a thirty-minute countdown, alongside timed traversal elsewhere. Ordinary turn-based combat does not erase those exceptions. Calendar choices, relationship planning, combat menus, dungeon movement and camera handling create additional complexity.

Try this first. Judge the opening conversations and presentation, but keep the late countdown warning in the decision from the start. Establish a deliberate shared-viewing or help arrangement before investing in a long campaign if those required operations are unacceptable alone.

Aiden's complete scene and the source notes follow on the next page.

AIDEN AND TANK / THE COALITION CHORUS

Niggas, games up.

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Niggas, take turns.

Niggas, dance later.

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Niggas, stay petty.

Niggas, we're good.

P071 / THE COMIC SCENE AND SOURCES

Persona 5 Royal

AIDEN AT THE SUMMIT / The Calendar Has Rejected My Surprise Event

Persona's crowded calendar made Mika inspect the summit schedule with renewed hostility. I had inserted a surprise founder's address between dinner and Velvet's show, using a font small enough to resemble a footnote.

Velvet found it anyway. "Why is your footnote twenty minutes?" "Context." "Nigga, I have a costume change, not a sabbatical."

Kit wanted her promised karaoke time protected. Remy wanted his microphone checked before he performed. Mercedes wanted the room quiet for one final recording test. Every real activity had a person waiting behind it.

I tried moving my address into the break. Rosa pointed out that a break containing an address became another event. Shawna suggested I deliver the speech upstairs to the mirror, which had already demonstrated remarkable patience with my work.

Mika removed the item. The schedule became legible again. I kept the little speech in my pocket because a man can retain private delusions without printing them on everybody else's evening.

Tank asked whether that principle also covered the dessert announcement. I reluctantly confirmed that it did.

Aiden's verdict. The stylish ensemble can be appealing, but its required countdowns and traversal keep the no-rush warning decisive. Our calendar has survived one attempted invasion by a twenty-minute footnote.

Evidence desk / checked 20 September 2026

Exact Royal PC listing supports premise. Royal-specific walkthroughs corroborate required Okumura time limits; no PC option removing them was verified. Story interest is separated from full-route suitability.

Source 1: <https://store.steampowered.com/app/1687950/>

Source 2: <https://gamefaqs.gamespot.com/ps4/260936-persona-5-royal/faqs/78256/week-24-october-1st-october-9th-okumuras-palace>

Source 3: https://www.neoseeker.com/persona-5-royal/Okumura%27s_Space_Station

AIDEN AND TANK / THE COALITION CHORUS

Niggas, games up.

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Niggas, read first.

Niggas, pick freely.

Niggas, no rush.

Niggas, sign here.

Niggas, stay petty.

Niggas, we're good.

P072 / READ THE CATCH FIRST

BRAVELY DEFAULT II

Edition considered: PC release

Travel with four heroes through a crystal-centered fantasy, using a battle rhythm that asks when to save actions and when to commit them.

What you do. Learn an ordinary attack and Default, observe the next turn, and combine jobs, abilities, and equipment as the adventure develops.

Direction + buttons | Some real-time demands | Single-player; a friend can share the decisions

Main catch. Untimed input is declared, but Brave Points and jobs create heavy tactics; directional control may still require uncomfortable holds.

Why it might click. Four heroes undertake a crystal-centered fantasy journey with jobs and abilities that can be combined in different ways. The signature battle idea is deciding when to store action capacity and when to spend it, creating a recognizable rhythm of preparation and commitment.

The full catch. The PC publisher declares play without timed input and adjustable difficulty. That helps pace, while Brave Points, primary and secondary jobs, equipment and enemy behavior still create a heavy tactical load. Exploration requires directional control; a no-timed-input declaration does not establish that movement is comfortable without holds.

Try this first. Choose a comfortable difficulty and learn one ordinary attack and one Default action in the early guidance. Observe what changes on the next turn before planning elaborate job combinations or trying to bank an entire party's future at once.

Aiden's complete scene and the source notes follow on the next page.

AIDEN AND TANK / THE COALITION CHORUS

Niggas, games up.

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P072 / THE COMIC SCENE AND SOURCES

BRAVELY DEFAULT II

AIDEN AT THE SUMMIT / The Brave Points Are Actually My Wife's Patience

BRAVELY DEFAULT's stored and spent actions gave me a theory of marriage. I could accumulate goodwill through useful work and spend it on one magnificent surprise. Shawna listened with folded arms.

"What magnificent surprise?" "The theory is preliminary." "Then keep it theoretical, nigga."

I carried water, returned unused ribbons, and found Kit's glasses on top of the karaoke folder. Three useful actions. I began to feel extraordinarily rich in imaginary domestic currency.

Then I suggested a joint portrait above the dance floor. Shawna said she wanted a dance floor, not a shrine. My entire account disappeared in one sentence.

Rae and Nia were comparing the budget's remaining choices. Nia proposed saving a small reserve for genuine surprises. Rae said a broken cable counted; an unexpected portrait did not. Their agreement sounded suspiciously informed by recent evidence.

I returned to carrying water. Shawna touched my hand when I brought hers. No score appeared, no credit was issued, and the moment was better for being impossible to invoice.

Aiden's verdict. The crystal journey's stored-action idea gives its battles a recognizable rhythm, with jobs and holds still requiring consideration. Our host's imaginary goodwill account cannot purchase a surprise shrine above the dance floor.

Evidence desk / checked 20 September 2026

Exact PC listing explains Brave/Default, jobs and four heroes; developer declares no timed input and adjustable difficulty. Mixed pace distinguishes exploration from waiting decisions, not a claim of required timers. Holds untested.

Source 1: <https://store.steampowered.com/app/1446650/>

AIDEN AND TANK / THE COALITION CHORUS

Niggas, games up.

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P073 / A PLACE TO START

Slay the Spire

Edition considered: PC original game

Build a deck from limited choices, enjoying the moment a useful card-and-relic combination gives the next encounter a different shape.

What you do. Read attack and defensive cards, spend available energy, and choose cards or relics that develop a plan across the climb's encounters.

Mouse / pointer | Usually waits for choices | Single-player; a friend can share the decisions

Main catch. Card effects and energy require reading and planning; test targeting gestures, and expect losing runs as part of the structure.

Why it might click. Build a deck while climbing a changing sequence of encounters, choosing cards and relics that make the next fight play differently. The appeal is recognizing a useful combination and gradually shaping a plan from imperfect, limited choices rather than executing a fixed routine.

The full catch. The developer declares play without timed input, mouse-only play and saving at any time. Card text, energy, status effects and deck interactions still demand reading and planning. Test card selection and targeting for drag or hold comfort; losing a run is part of the structure, not evidence that the trial was wasted.

Try this first. Begin with the first available character and examine one attack card and one defensive card before playing either. Try one encounter and judge whether the tradeoff is satisfying without aiming to finish the entire climb on the first visit.

Aiden's complete scene and the source notes follow on the next page.

AIDEN AND TANK / THE COALITION CHORUS

Niggas, games up.

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P073 / THE COMIC SCENE AND SOURCES

Slay the Spire

AIDEN AT THE SUMMIT / The Deck Contains Too Many Founder Cards

Slay the Spire's changing deck made Remy turn our remaining budget requests into little cards. He wrote each expense clearly and asked me which ones supported the evening we actually wanted.

I selected HOST'S PORTRAIT LIGHTING. Rae slid it back. "Try a card with another person's name." Velvet selected the stage payment. Rosa selected staff time. Kit selected the microphone check. Each card had an obvious effect, which made my proposal for a second ceremonial reveal look increasingly ornamental.

Nia added a reserve card and put it beside an equipment repair estimate. Mika liked having the tradeoffs visible. They also admitted they still wanted the giant shadow effect, which fortunately used equipment already paid for.

I tried sneaking my portrait card underneath the reserve. Shawna caught the edge without looking. Nigga, this woman had years of practice detecting suspicious spending from changes in my breathing. We kept the useful cards. Remy drew a tiny crown on his fanfare request and set it aside with excellent grace when Mercedes reminded him the keyboard was already there.

Aiden's verdict. The evolving deck can reward discovering combinations, with reading and losing runs part of the structure. Our budget deck improved after several cards stopped being different names for my portrait.

Evidence desk / checked 20 September 2026

Original PC game listing supports deckbuilding/roguelike structure and declares Mouse Only, no timed input and Save Anytime. Card manipulation comfort and full-path suitability are not independently verified.

Source 1: <https://store.steampowered.com/app/646570/>

AIDEN AND TANK / THE COALITION CHORUS

Niggas, games up.

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Niggas, we're good.

P074 / READ THE CATCH FIRST

Monster Train

Edition considered: PC original game

Defend a train through stacked battle spaces, where choosing a creature's floor can matter as much as choosing the next card.

What you do. Place units on floors, play spells, and develop the deck through upgrades while defending the train across an ordinary solo run.

Mouse / pointer | Usually waits for choices | Single-player; a friend can share the decisions

Main catch. Exclude clock-driven Hell Rush from this trial; floor placement and card effects remain complex, with drag comfort unverified.

Why it might click. Defend a train across stacked battle spaces by combining units, spells and upgrades into a developing deck. The vertical layout changes the familiar card-battle question: where a creature stands can matter as much as which card is played next.

The full catch. Use an ordinary solo run for this proposal. The publisher explicitly describes Hell Rush multiplayer as a real-time, clock-driven competition, so exclude it from a no-rush trial. Multiple floors, unit placement, card upgrades and interacting effects still create a substantial mental load; dragging and held-input behavior require checking.

Try this first. Open a solo run and inspect one unit's placement and one spell before advancing the fight. Keep attention on the immediate floor arrangement; there is no need to plan a perfect deck or enter any competitive challenge to understand the attraction.

Aiden's complete scene and the source notes follow on the next page.

AIDEN AND TANK / THE COALITION CHORUS

Niggas, games up.

Niggas, pens out.

Niggas, chairs in.

Niggas, snacks here.

Niggas, receipts ready.

Niggas, lights on.

Niggas, mic check.

Niggas, take turns.

Niggas, dance later.

Niggas, read first.

Niggas, pick freely.

Niggas, no rush.

Niggas, sign here.

Niggas, stay petty.

Niggas, we're good.

P074 / THE COMIC SCENE AND SOURCES

Monster Train

AIDEN AT THE SUMMIT / The Train Has a Dining Car with Conditions

Monster Train's stacked spaces made Tank arrange three serving trays vertically on a display stand. He called it the coalition's refreshment express. Rosa asked who had approved the unstable top layer. “The conductor,” he said. She removed it. “The engineer disagrees.”

Rae wanted the good crackers on the middle tray where people could reach them. Kit wanted the stand away from the music equipment. Nia wanted the bottom shelf to stop collecting everyone's abandoned papers.

I proposed a ceremonial dining carriage built around the whole buffet. Mika looked interested for one dangerous second, then checked the actual space and shook their head. Our event planner could resist extravagance when geometry finally got involved.

June took a plate and told Dez the Blue Comet had served sandwiches from an ironing board. Dez corrected the history: it was her ironing board, and June still had one of its covers.

Tank moved the stand. Nigga, our train acquired a safe route while another branch of the restitution campaign opened beside the cheese.

Aiden’s verdict. The stacked card battles give positioning a distinct role; exclude the clock-driven mode and test gestures. Our refreshment train has moved onto a safer track under Rosa's uncompromising engineering supervision.

Evidence desk / checked 20 September 2026

Original-game publisher page supports three vertical fields/deckbuilding and explicitly identifies Hell Rush as timed real-time multiplayer. Waits applies to the proposed ordinary solo mode, not all modes; holds remain unchecked.

Source 1: <https://store.steampowered.com/app/1102190/>

AIDEN AND TANK / THE COALITION CHORUS

Niggas, games up.	Niggas, pens out.	Niggas, chairs in.	Niggas, snacks here.	Niggas, receipts ready.
Niggas, lights on.	Niggas, mic check.	Niggas, take turns.	Niggas, dance later.	Niggas, read first.
Niggas, pick freely.	Niggas, no rush.	Niggas, sign here.	Niggas, stay petty.	Niggas, we're good.

P075 / READ THE CATCH FIRST

Griftlands

Edition considered: PC release

Navigate a rough science-fiction world where separate conversation and combat decks make negotiations, alliances, and grudges matter mechanically as well as narratively.

What you do. Read negotiation or combat cards, choose them in encounters, and manage relationships whose effects can follow the protagonist into later situations.

Mouse / pointer | Usually waits for choices | Single-player; a friend can share the decisions

Main catch. Two decks and relationship consequences require substantial text and tracking; every gesture or possible timing exception has not been audited.

Why it might click. Three separate protagonists navigate a rough science-fiction world through fights, negotiations and relationships. Maintaining different decks for talking and combat makes social encounters mechanically substantial, while choices about allies and enemies can follow the character into later situations.

The full catch. Two decks, relationship effects, faction loyalties and run-based consequences make this more demanding than a small casual card game. Considerable text explains abilities and social stakes. Turn-based card decisions support deliberation, but no full-path guarantee about every gesture or timing exception has been independently established.

Try this first. Start the opening character's story and read one negotiation card in context before building a grand strategy. Try one exchange, observing both what the card does and why the other person cares, then decide whether managing conversation this way is enjoyable.

Aiden's complete scene and the source notes follow on the next page.

AIDEN AND TANK / THE COALITION CHORUS

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Niggas, stay petty.

Niggas, we're good.

P075 / THE COMIC SCENE AND SOURCES

Griftlands

AIDEN AT THE SUMMIT / The Negotiation Deck Has a Compliment in It

Griftlands separated talking from fighting. I suggested the summit needed two decks too: one for negotiation and one for winning. Nia asked why I thought those were different objectives. Rae said they were different whenever I negotiated with the hotel. Nigga, the table had stopped offering me easy openings.

Velvet wanted a clearer introduction before her number. Remy wanted his stage name pronounced with a dramatic pause. Kit wanted nobody shouting over the first note of her song. They negotiated three sentences and a cue without anyone declaring victory.

Nia complimented Rae's repair of the table. Rae, who could discuss a bent bracket for an hour, answered with six words and knocked a cracker onto the floor. The negotiation deck had acquired an unexpectedly powerful card.

I bent to retrieve it and struck my head beneath the table. Shawna asked whether this was my fighting deck. Tank said I appeared to be losing against furniture.

Rae laughed, Nia relaxed, and somebody gave me a napkin for my dignity. No alliance changed hands, but the atmosphere improved considerably.

Aiden's verdict. The separate negotiation and combat decks make relationships mechanically distinctive, with substantial tracking retained. Our most effective conversational card was a sincere compliment that briefly defeated a highly competent mechanic.

Evidence desk / checked 20 September 2026

Publisher supports three campaigns, separate negotiation/combat decks and persistent social consequences. Waits describes core card decisions; held gestures and complete-path exceptions have not been tested.

Source 1: <https://store.steampowered.com/app/601840/>

AIDEN AND TANK / THE COALITION CHORUS

Niggas, games up.	Niggas, pens out.	Niggas, chairs in.	Niggas, snacks here.	Niggas, receipts ready.
Niggas, lights on.	Niggas, mic check.	Niggas, take turns.	Niggas, dance later.	Niggas, read first.
Niggas, pick freely.	Niggas, no rush.	Niggas, sign here.	Niggas, stay petty.	Niggas, we're good.

P076 / A PLACE TO START

Dicey Dungeons

Edition considered: PC release

Enter an absurd dungeon game show as walking dice, turning rolled numbers into equipment effects and small tactical puzzles with lively presentation.

What you do. Read an equipment requirement, assign a rolled die, and observe its effect before choosing another placement or continuing through the dungeon.

Mouse / pointer | Usually waits for choices | Single-player; a friend can share the decisions

Main catch. Arithmetic and equipment conditions require thought; test placement gestures, and begin with the initial character before learning different rule sets.

Why it might click. Walking dice face a peculiar dungeon game show, turning rolled numbers into attacks and other equipment effects. Different characters change the rules enough to make a familiar-looking die produce very different little tactical problems, with lively art and music supporting the absurdity.

The full catch. Equipment conditions, arithmetic and random outcomes require thought; later characters change the rules substantially. Turn-based play is the core, but placing dice may involve dragging or other gestures worth testing. Begin with the initial character rather than treating every class or bonus episode as equally simple.

Try this first. Use the first available character and try assigning one die to one piece of equipment. Read the requirement, observe the result, and judge the placement gesture before considering a whole dungeon or a different character with an entirely new rule system.

Aiden's complete scene and the source notes follow on the next page.

AIDEN AND TANK / THE COALITION CHORUS

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Niggas, stay petty.

Niggas, we're good.

P076 / THE COMIC SCENE AND SOURCES

Dicey Dungeons

AIDEN AT THE SUMMIT / The Dungeon Prize Is a Voucher for More Dungeon

Dicey Dungeons' absurd game show inspired Remy to host a draw for the evening's remaining decorative prizes. I supplied sealed envelopes and a voice suited to announcing a small monarchy. Kit won a voucher for one priority karaoke request. She pointed out she'd already negotiated a turn. "Then you've doubled your fortune," I said. "You've printed my existing fortune twice, Aiden."

Rae won a gold bottle opener shaped like my initials. Nia offered to trade her plain one. Rae refused because the ridiculous opener was beginning to amuse her, which I chose to count as brand success. June drew FREE JUKEBOX CHOICE. Dez intercepted it before she could celebrate. "That voucher expires in 1967." Remy laughed so hard he dropped the remaining envelopes.

Velvet collected them and found three prizes labeled MYSTERY. They were empty. I said mystery required imagination. Shawna supplied three drink tokens, all equal, and turned my defective prize system into something people could actually use.

The host retained one empty envelope as evidence of his apparently unlimited potential.

Aiden's verdict. The walking-dice spectacle has a distinctive comic appeal, with arithmetic and placement still needing attention. Our prize show improved once somebody put actual value inside the envelopes marked mystery.

Evidence desk / checked 20 September 2026

Developer store supports characters/equipment; official project wiki describes turn-based dice allocation. Drag/hold alternatives and every episode are not verified; recommendation targets the initial character's basic loop.

- Source 1: <https://store.steampowered.com/app/861540/>
- Source 2: https://wiki.diceydungeons.com/doku.php?id=dicey_dungeons

AIDEN AND TANK / THE COALITION CHORUS

Niggas, games up.	Niggas, pens out.	Niggas, chairs in.	Niggas, snacks here.	Niggas, receipts ready.
Niggas, lights on.	Niggas, mic check.	Niggas, take turns.	Niggas, dance later.	Niggas, read first.
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P077 / A PLACE TO START

Balatro

Edition considered: PC base game

Turn familiar-looking poker hands into a changing score puzzle, where Jokers and modifiers can make a modest combination unexpectedly powerful.

What you do. Build a recognizable hand, read Joker effects, and select or arrange cards to improve the combination for the next scoring target.

Mouse / pointer | Usually waits for choices | Single-player; a friend can share the decisions

Main catch. Untimed mouse play is declared, but scoring modifiers and boss rules add memory demands; selection and rearrangement gestures need testing.

Why it might click. Poker-like hands become ingredients in a single-player score-building puzzle, transformed by Jokers and other modifiers. The attraction is watching a modest combination become unexpectedly powerful and deciding how each new card changes the plan for the next target.

The full catch. The developer declares play without timed input and mouse-only play. Hand recognition, scoring modifiers, changing boss rules and reading several effects at once still take attention. Card rearrangement and selection need a gesture check; a familiar deck does not mean all the surrounding rules are familiar or memory-light.

Try this first. Try the opening explanation and build one clearly recognized hand. Read one Joker's effect in plain language before buying or arranging a complicated combination, then decide whether discovering the score interaction feels satisfying rather than like unwanted arithmetic homework.

Aiden's complete scene and the source notes follow on the next page.

AIDEN AND TANK / THE COALITION CHORUS

Niggas, games up.

Niggas, pens out.

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Niggas, receipts ready.

Niggas, lights on.

Niggas, mic check.

Niggas, take turns.

Niggas, dance later.

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Niggas, stay petty.

Niggas, we're good.

P077 / THE COMIC SCENE AND SOURCES

Balatro

AIDEN AT THE SUMMIT / The Joker Has Entered the Reparations Budget

Balatro's surprising modifiers made June propose calculating interest on the Blue Comet jacket claim. Dez argued it should run backward because the story had entertained June for decades. June requested a less ridiculous calculation.

Nia put down her pen. "I'm not creating a financial product out of your flirting." Both veterans objected to the final word with suspicious speed.

Remy made a Joker card bearing my face. Its alleged effect was to double any decorating expense while reducing the host's ability to explain it. Velvet considered the rule remarkably well balanced.

I attempted a counter-card granting free speeches. Kit rejected it before I finished drawing the border. Rae proposed that all imaginary gains remain imaginary, an excellent safeguard for a table surrounded by actual casino carpet.

June named a modest, concrete settlement: Dez would look for the saved alteration pattern so they could discuss restoring the jacket, then buy dinner. Dez accepted dinner immediately and searched for a loophole in restoring.

Nigga, fifty-nine years of compound argument had resolved into two people spending another afternoon together.

Aiden's verdict. The score-building combinations can be satisfying, with modifiers and selection demands still real. Our imaginary interest calculation settled into a practical afternoon and a Joker that describes the host too accurately.

Evidence desk / checked 20 September 2026

Exact base listing supports poker-inspired deckbuilding, Jokers and developer-declared no timed input/Mouse Only. No real-money gambling claim or guaranteed hold-free card manipulation is made.

Source 1: <https://store.steampowered.com/app/2379780/>

AIDEN AND TANK / THE COALITION CHORUS

Niggas, games up.	Niggas, pens out.	Niggas, chairs in.	Niggas, snacks here.	Niggas, receipts ready.
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P078 / A PLACE TO START

Cobalt Core

Edition considered: PC release

Meet a small spaceship crew caught in a time-loop mystery, using card choices to reposition the ship as well as attack.

What you do. Inspect incoming fire, play movement or attack cards, and shift along one line to avoid shots or align weapons during encounters.

Mouse / pointer | Usually waits for choices | Single-player; a friend can share the decisions

Main catch. Crew decks, ship layout, and incoming fire interact; gesture comfort and the full sequence of encounters remain untested.

Why it might click. A small crew's personalities and a time-loop mystery sit inside spaceship card battles. Moving along a single line makes positioning part of the card choice: avoiding a shot or lining up a weapon can matter as much as adding more damage.

The full catch. Crew decks, ship layout, incoming fire and upgrades create interacting information to track. The publisher invites play at one's own pace, but gesture comfort and the complete sequence of encounters are not independently tested. This is a card-driven tactical game, not a reflex flying game, yet it still requires attentive planning.

Try this first. Inspect one incoming attack and one movement card during the opening guidance. See what shifting the ship changes before building a multi-card sequence, then decide whether the crew's banter gives you a reason to explore another encounter.

Aiden's complete scene and the source notes follow on the next page.

AIDEN AND TANK / THE COALITION CHORUS

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P078 / THE COMIC SCENE AND SOURCES

Cobalt Core

AIDEN AT THE SUMMIT / The Time Loop Has Replayed My Card Decline

Cobalt Core's crew faced a time-loop mystery. Our crew faced the payment terminal returning to the same cheerful screen every time I tapped my card. Tank began narrating the recurrence. "Again the captain confronts his destiny." "Nigga, stop." "Again destiny requests another method." The card wasn't declined; the reader had lost connection. Mika found the floor manager while Nia checked that we weren't approving duplicate charges. Rae moved the cable away from a chair wheel and discovered the practical villain. Shawna stood beside me without making a joke, which was suspiciously loving under the circumstances. I thanked her. "Don't thank me yet. I'm saving it for when the room's quieter." The next attempt worked. Velvet's remaining deposit was confirmed, and she relaxed her shoulders in a way I hadn't noticed she'd been holding them. Remy brought her the confirmation without a fanfare. I asked Tank to retire the narration. He nodded solemnly. "The captain has escaped the loop." Nigga added applause, and several traitors joined him. **Aiden's verdict.** The crew and time-loop mystery give these spaceship card battles personality, with interacting systems still substantial. Our payment loop ended through a cable repair and a carefully checked confirmation.

Evidence desk / checked 20 September 2026

Publisher supports card-driven single-axis combat, crew stories and playing at one's pace. No continuous-action flight claim; complete hold/gesture comfort remains unverified.
Source 1: <https://store.steampowered.com/app/2179850/>

AIDEN AND TANK / THE COALITION CHORUS

Niggas, games up.	Niggas, pens out.	Niggas, chairs in.	Niggas, snacks here.	Niggas, receipts ready.
Niggas, lights on.	Niggas, mic check.	Niggas, take turns.	Niggas, dance later.	Niggas, read first.
Niggas, pick freely.	Niggas, no rush.	Niggas, sign here.	Niggas, stay petty.	Niggas, we're good.

P079 / READ THE CATCH FIRST

Wildfrost

Edition considered: PC release

Build a companion-card group in a frozen world, enjoying how a carefully chosen move can change attacks several turns into the future.

What you do. Read friendly and enemy counters, place companion cards, and choose moves that alter positioning, effects, and the order of upcoming actions.

Mouse / pointer | Usually waits for choices | Single-player; a friend can share the decisions

Main catch. Counters measure turns rather than seconds, but attack order and survival demand planning; card-placement comfort still needs checking.

Why it might click. Build a traveling group of companion cards in a frozen world, arranging their effects and attacks to work together. The distinctive pleasure is planning around visible action counters, so that a carefully chosen move changes what happens several turns later.

The full catch. The counters measure turns until actions, not a requirement to click within seconds. Even so, attack order, positioning, status effects and companion survival can be demanding, and a cute appearance does not predict an easy run. Card placement gestures and all-path input comfort remain checks rather than verified assurances.

Try this first. Read one friendly counter and one enemy counter, then use the opening guidance to observe what advances them. Try predicting only the next action before attempting a long chain of effects or comparing every possible leader and deck.

Aiden's complete scene and the source notes follow on the next page.

AIDEN AND TANK / THE COALITION CHORUS

Niggas, games up.

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Niggas, stay petty.

Niggas, we're good.

P079 / THE COMIC SCENE AND SOURCES

Wildfrost

AIDEN AT THE SUMMIT / The Frost Counter Is on the Dessert Table

Wildfrost's visible counters made me obsess over the dessert station. A little card told staff when to bring out the chilled trays. I asked whether it represented our remaining turns before catastrophe.

Rosa read it. "It represents dessert."

Tank wanted to speed up the sequence. Rae wanted him to stop hovering over the good crackers while pretending to care about temperature. Nia passed Rae the bowl and received a smile that had nothing to do with fiscal policy.

Kit marked her rehearsal break on the schedule so it wouldn't collide with service. Mercedes agreed to test the final quiet passage earlier. Two small changes made the evening feel less like a set of people waiting to interrupt one another.

I offered an emergency countdown display. Mika said the existing card was perfectly adequate. June told me the Blue Comet had managed with Dez shouting from the kitchen. Dez said June had usually ignored that system too.

The trays arrived. Nobody froze, nothing exploded, and the coalition survived without acquiring another screen showing numbers I intended to misunderstand.

Aiden's verdict. The companion cards and turn counters create an interesting planning problem, with survival and placement demands retained. Our dessert counter has successfully measured service time without becoming a dramatic emergency broadcast.

Evidence desk / checked 20 September 2026

Publisher explicitly explains turn-based battles and counters measured in turns. This distinguishes counters from real-time deadlines; no low-difficulty or hold-free promise is inferred from visual style.

Source 1: <https://store.steampowered.com/app/1811990/>

AIDEN AND TANK / THE COALITION CHORUS

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Niggas, mic check.

Niggas, take turns.

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Niggas, stay petty.

Niggas, we're good.

P080 / A PLACE TO START

Clubhouse Games: 51 Worldwide Classics

Edition considered: Nintendo Switch; individual games must be assessed separately

Find one enjoyable little ritual within a collection of distinct board, card, and other games, each offering its own in-game explanation.

What you do. Start with Four in a Row, read that game's instructions, and test selecting and placing a piece in the chosen player setup.

Mixed controls | Some real-time demands | Co-op details need checking

Main catch. Assess each game separately: the collection includes reflex games, and multiplayer, touch, motion, and undo options vary by title.

Why it might click. The collection offers many small, distinct games with in-game explanations, from familiar boards to cards and more active diversions. Its useful promise is variety within one package: it may be possible to find one pleasing little ritual without adopting a long campaign.

The full catch. Assess individual games, not the collection as one control profile. Nintendo explicitly distinguishes strategic choices such as Four-in-a-row from reflex games such as Slot Cars and Toy Boxing. Multiplayer, motion, touch and undo availability vary by game. Shared competitive play is not automatically cooperative play.

Try this first. Open Four-in-a-row and read its own instructions, then test selecting and placing a piece in a local or solo arrangement without an added household timer. Check that game's controls and player setup before trying a second title.

Aiden's complete scene and the source notes follow on the next page.

AIDEN AND TANK / THE COALITION CHORUS

Niggas, games up.

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Niggas, take turns.

Niggas, dance later.

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P080 / THE COMIC SCENE AND SOURCES

Clubhouse Games: 51 Worldwide Classics

AIDEN AT THE SUMMIT / Fifty-One Games and One Agreed Expense Sheet

Clubhouse Games offered a collection of small possibilities. I tried proposing fifty-one corresponding summit committees. Shawna took the pen out of my hand before committee number two could acquire stationery.

Rae selected a familiar board game for a short break. Nia sat beside her to watch, then asked to take the next turn when it came around. Nobody made a declaration about what this meant.

Kit and Remy compared the in-game explanations while Velvet checked the now confirmed show payment. Rosa put the final catering total beside it. Mika added the room charge and circled the modest reserve.

June and Dez agreed that their separate jacket arrangement belonged in their own handwriting, however much Nia's legal-looking paper tempted them. Their settlement didn't require everyone else to inherit the 1967 jukebox dispute.

I approved the financial sheet. It wasn't the final coalition treaty, merely numbers we understood and commitments we could honor. Tank applauded once, with his hands safely away from food.

"Historic, nigga." I bowed. Shawna pulled me into the empty chair before history ordered another banner.

Aiden's verdict. The collection offers many separate trials rather than one universal fit; choose individual games carefully. Our summit has agreed its financial sheet and wisely declined to establish fifty-one committees.

Evidence desk / checked 20 September 2026

Nintendo confirms collection/tutorials and explicitly separates strategic/reflex games; proposed trial is Four-in-a-row only. Collection-level mixed pace/input must not certify every included game. Native co-op scope and game-specific holds are unverified.

Source 1: <https://www.nintendo.com/us/store/products/clubhouse-games-51-worldwide-classics-switch/>

AIDEN AND TANK / THE COALITION CHORUS

Niggas, games up.	Niggas, pens out.	Niggas, chairs in.	Niggas, snacks here.	Niggas, receipts ready.
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The Money Is Agreed and the Furniture Is Still an Argument

The financial sheet fit on one page when we stopped describing every expense as a historic investment. Performer payments. Staff time. Room charge. Equipment already in place. A small reserve for things that genuinely broke, distinct from things I became excited about while walking past a rental catalogue. Nia read the categories aloud. Rae checked the numbers against the receipts. Kit caught a duplicated lamp charge and looked so satisfied that I almost ordered a small trophy before remembering the entire fucking meeting.

Velvet received the confirmation she'd been waiting for. She put her phone away and became interested in the room again. Remy offered his arm. They went to check the microphone together, discussing a deliberately terrible pun he intended to put into the introduction. She said it was awful. He said that was its function. She agreed it performed its function flawlessly.

Rosa confirmed the additional staff time and went to speak with the kitchen. Mercedes and Porsche checked the recording schedule against the show order. Mika marked the approved equipment on the miniature floor plan, then looked at the actual doorway and frowned. The budget was intelligible. The rooms still required work. I had mistaken paying for square footage for knowing what to do with it, a confusion apparently common among niggas wearing ceremonial jackets indoors.

June and Dez kept their copied invoice in a plain envelope. Both sides. June wrote TURN OVER on the front in enormous letters. Dez wrote SAME TO YOU on the back. Their private jacket arrangement included looking for the old alteration pattern and having dinner afterward. The original jacket remained with Dez for the moment, which June permitted while describing herself as extraordinarily patient. Dez called this a promising new direction in historical fiction.

Nobody signed the final coalition charter. We had agreed financial terms, confirmed immediate payments, and recorded unresolved decorative claims for later review. I remained optimistic about those claims because optimism is cheap until you arrange a spotlight for it. Shawna read the little unresolved line, looked at me, and said nothing. Marriage contains silences with the tensile strength of steel.

AIDEN AND TANK / THE COALITION CHORUS

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Niggas, take turns.

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Niggas, stay petty.

Niggas, we're good.

Nia put the pen down. Rae asked whether she'd like a little air before the next room. Nia said yes before making it sound more considered. Kit handed them the room map, then noticed she'd given them her karaoke list instead. Everybody laughed, including Kit. She retrieved the list and told them the good balcony was marked on the actual map, which Mika still needed to verify. Even flirtation had encountered our venue problem.

I watched them leave and kept every helpful suggestion inside my own head. Shawna noticed. She linked her arm through mine. "You can learn." I whispered that I possessed several advanced qualifications she hadn't examined tonight. "Then stop enrolling yourself in committees." Her smile gave my future a much more interesting shape than the financial statement.

Tank carried the budget into the next room. Mika followed with the model hotel. June and Dez continued arguing fondly about whether alternating songs meant one each or whichever one sounded better. The Second Great War had survived its treasury meeting. Its armies now needed somewhere sensible to sit, and I was about to discover that a room could be expensive in ways a receipt didn't explain.

AIDEN AND TANK / THE COALITION CHORUS

Niggas, games up.	Niggas, pens out.	Niggas, chairs in.	Niggas, snacks here.	Niggas, receipts ready.
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Credits, source limits and the paperwork we actually mean

Creative direction: Nolan. The Second Great Butch vs. Stud War / Coalition Edition: new ChatGPT-generated comic prose and production, retaining the researched game cards and selection mechanics. This is a separate user-directed alternate companion; previous editions and source novels remain intact. All fictional participants are adults; Lillian remains the reader.

Revision base: the Tellings Cut at Sodelin/Ten-Toes-Down commit 0e3fd666e7e1a0907e1e4dcd8ed3213cfee79a04. The earlier edition was grounded in sampled Niggatorial Tellings passages. The new summit cast, caucuses, romances and treaty are original companion fiction; they are not represented as recovered source canon. Editorial notes record the reading and rewriting scope.

The optional traits, tokens and signed-dice layer take inspiration from Fate. The Panorama's catalogue coordinates, vetoes, snack amendment, incidents and appeals are original comic selection rules; this is not a substitute for the Fate rulebooks.

Fate reference pages consulted:

<https://fate-srd.com/fate-accelerated/how-do-stuff-outcomes-actions-and-approaches> and

<https://fate-srd.com/fate-accelerated/aspects-fate-points>. No Fate logos, illustrations or fonts are used.

This work is based on Fate Core System and Fate Accelerated Edition, products of Evil Hat Productions, LLC, developed, authored, and edited by Leonard Balsera, Brian Engard, Jeremy Keller, Ryan Macklin, Mike Olson, Clark Valentine, Amanda Valentine, Fred Hicks, and Rob Donoghue, and licensed for our use under the Creative Commons Attribution 3.0 Unported license (<https://creativecommons.org/licenses/by/3.0/>).

Game titles identify the corresponding games. No game code, ROMs, full manuals or third-party artwork are included. Availability and controls can vary by edition, region and platform. The sources support their stated claims; no purchase, installation or personal fit has been established by this book.

This edition includes frequent non-hateful reclaimed in-group language, strong profanity, fictional cocaine references and consensual non-graphic sexual innuendo. The fictional crew chorus intentionally repeats the reclaimed plural fifteen times on each fixed PDF page, separate from game facts. EPUB pagination is reflowable; its chorus appears at chapter boundaries. Fiction does not describe developers, real readers or entire identity groups.

The First Great Butch vs. Stud War of 1967, the Blue Comet Social Club, its veterans and the present summit are fictional. They are not claims about actual LGBTQ history. The book uses overlapping personal identities and individual disagreements rather than treating butches, studs, lesbians, drag performers and trans people as mutually exclusive populations.

Each case names its inspected sources and the limits of those sources. Store descriptions and developer feature declarations are not a playthrough of every route. The companion evidence ledger records editorial tags separately from source declarations. Availability and features may change after the check date.

AIDEN AND TANK / THE COALITION CHORUS

Niggas, games up.	Niggas, pens out.	Niggas, chairs in.	Niggas, snacks here.	Niggas, receipts ready.
Niggas, lights on.	Niggas, mic check.	Niggas, take turns.	Niggas, dance later.	Niggas, read first.
Niggas, pick freely.	Niggas, no rush.	Niggas, sign here.	Niggas, stay petty.	Niggas, we're good.